

COMPREHENSIVE REVIEW

Psychosocial Effects of Romantic Breakups During Emerging Adulthood: A Systematic Review

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Received: 17 March 2025 | **Revised:** 25 July 2025 | **Accepted:** 30 July 2025

Funding: This work was supported by national funding from the Portuguese Foundation for Science and Technology (UIDB/00050/2020) and a doctoral grant attributed to J.G.F. (SFRH/BD/08585/2020).

Keywords: emerging adulthood | identity | intimacy | psychosocial adjustment | romantic breakup | systematic review

ABSTRACT

The current study reviewed the psychosocial effects of romantic breakups in emerging adulthood, particularly focused on evidence related to psychological health and psychosocial development, including aspects of identity and intimacy. A systematic literature search was conducted in accordance with the PRISMA guidelines across EBSCOhost, PubMed and Web of Science (ISI) databases. Studies with available evidence on psychosocial dimensions and emerging adult populations who had experienced a romantic breakup were included and subjected to review evaluation. Forty-seven studies were eligible for inclusion. Results showed several negative and positive psychosocial outcomes and supported the effect of breakups on changes in self-concept and interpersonal intimacy. Diverse factors influenced positive and negative adjustment. Specifically, individuals experiencing more challenges were especially those with insecure attachment, a history of childhood abuse and maladaptive coping strategies. Conversely, individuals employing adaptive coping mechanisms and personal resources such as emotional regulation and mentalization tended to exhibit better postbreakup outcomes. The long-term effects remain inconclusive, highlighting the need for further research. These findings underscore the complexity of breakup experiences and highlight the crucial role of supportive factors in shaping psychosocial adjustment. This first systematic review of the psychosocial effects of breakups suggested that interventions targeted at emerging adults should enhance psychosocial transformations and individuals' specific needs to prevent maladjustment to breakups and psychological problems.

1 | Introduction

1.1 | Romantic Breakups in Emerging Adulthood

Emerging adulthood is recognized as the period of life that offers the most opportunities for identity exploration and intimacy development (Arnett 2000). Romantic relationships become a fundamental human motivation because the salient developmental task of this period is forming and maintaining close relationships. However, because of their inherently unstable nature, the relationships can start and end repeatedly, becoming

one of the most distressing events in an individual's life (Priest et al. 2009). Dealing with and learning from breakups reveal one of the most inevitable challenges in human life (Lewandowski and Bizzoco 2007; Perilloux and Buss 2008; Snyder et al. 2006; Tashiro and Frazier 2003) and are associated with several aspects of psychosocial functioning (Sbarra et al. 2011).

The literature demonstrated that romantic experiences in emerging adulthood may potentially restrict future options or contribute to poorer choices in romantic life, which is widely related to mental health and emotional stability throughout

Summary

- Breakups during emerging adulthood are complex, multidimensional experiences and part of a normative developmental process.
- A breakup can be more than a distressing event; it offers the opportunity to redefine self-concept, reassess relational needs and promote personal growth.
- Diverse factors, such as attachment style, relationship experience, coping mechanisms and personal resources, influence postbreakup adjustment, highlighting the need for tailored interventions.
- Longitudinal research on the psychosocial long-term effects of romantic breakups requires further refinement.
- Interventions may benefit from extending beyond the immediate emotional support to also foster long-term developmental change during emerging adulthood (e.g., fostering secure attachment, promoting differentiation of self and enhancing adaptive intrapersonal and interpersonal functioning).

human life (e.g., Davila 2010). After a breakup, people tend to report changes in self-concept and how they relate to others (e.g., Lewandowski et al. 2006). Poorer interpersonal functioning over time can be predicted by maladaptive interpersonal experiences, such as unresolved romantic breakups (Davila 2010). Understanding the effect of relationship dissolution on the self is important due to the central role of relationships in identity development (Arnett 2000) and the extent of repercussions in later stages of life (Arnett et al. 2014).

1.2 | Breakup Effects on Psychological Health and Psychosocial Development

The previous literature has largely focused on the impact of breakups on psychological health, showing that individuals who have ended a recent romantic relationship exhibit lower levels of psychological well-being (Boelen and Reijntjes 2008; Chung et al. 2002, 2003; Studley and Chung 2015; Verhallen et al. 2019) and higher levels of depression and anxiety, compared to those who are in a relationship or single (Boelen and Reijntjes 2008; Hope et al. 1999; Palacio-González et al. 2016, 2017; Rhoades et al. 2011; Sbarra and Emery 2005). In fact, the aftermath of breakups carries significant implications for mental health, with some studies considering it as one of the leading causes of suicide among young people (Fordwood et al. 2007; Monroe et al. 1999). The effects of breakups have been widely addressed due to the multitude of negative physical and emotional responses, such as feelings of disappointment and insecurity (Davis et al. 2003), as well as loss of self-confidence (Ross 1999, cited in Rajabi and Nikpoor 2018). Beyond individual functioning, it can negatively affect the level of social integration, reduce social networks (Yılmaz et al. 2021) and cause academic and professional difficulties (Ross 1999, cited in Rajabi and Nikpoor 2018).

It is important to acknowledge that breakups have also been associated with personal growth, fostering resilience and

self-discovery and the improvement of the quality of future romantic relationships (Samios et al. 2014; Tashiro and Frazier 2003). Some studies investigated the possibility of positive life changes following a breakup that may lead to increased competence and satisfaction in subsequent romantic relationships (Tashiro and Frazier 2003). In summary, there are studies focusing on both positive and negative effects of breakups on psychosocial adjustment. As a romantic dissolution has the potential to bring significant outcomes in an individual's life due to the need to adapt to a set of interconnected changes (Yılmaz et al. 2021), it is crucial to analyse these aspects in-depth, considering the potential for both adverse consequences and positive opportunities. However, navigating the extensive body of research on breakups is a real challenge due to the diverse nature and focus of these studies, along with some conflicting results. For example, Drew et al. (2004) found no significant main effect of relationship loss on depression, suggesting that breakups did not directly influence depressive symptomatology. In another study conducted by Chung et al. (2003), the overall impact of the breakup was positively associated with negative indicators of adjustment, encompassing both depression and anxiety.

The nature of these associations can be complex and vary across different developmental stages and different romantic experiences (Davila 2010). Some studies have shown that maladaptive individual experiences, such as insecure attachment style, are associated with poorer interpersonal adjustment over time (Davila 2010; Saffrey and Ehrenberg 2007), whereas secure attachment individuals tend to be more capable of managing stressful life events, including romantic breakups (Davis et al. 2003). Consequently, the termination of a partnership can be perceived and experienced differently according to individual patterns, coping responses and personal resources (Gilbert and Sifers 2011), as well as to the nature of the romantic relationship (Davila 2010). This nuanced nature of how breakup experiences in emerging adulthood can influence psychosocial adjustment highlights the need for further exploration and clarification in the literature.

1.3 | The Current Study: Bridging the Gap

To the best of our knowledge, no systematic reviews exist that comprehensively evaluate the psychosocial outcomes or the overall impact caused by a romantic breakup. There are several possible reasons for the absence of a comprehensive review of breakup psychosocial effects. First, breakups are a broad and multifaceted phenomenon that can be studied from multiple perspectives. Studies may emphasize different dimensions, methodologies and theoretical frameworks, which makes it challenging to define a clear research focus for a systematic review. Second, psychosocial functioning is a broad and complex concept that includes the relevant domains of identity and intimacy, relevant to age development and a diverse range of specific indices of adjustment (Montgomery 2005). Additionally, the diverse aspects of psychosocial functioning have been increasingly used in diverse analyses as outcomes, moderators or predictors. Altogether, it makes it particularly difficult to predefine the main research questions to evaluate through a systematic review. Nevertheless, this existing gap in the literature underscores the lack of integrated insights into

how romantic breakups affect young adults' lives particularly, as well as the need for focused research that provides a more explicit representation of psychosocial functioning following romantic breakups during the critical period of emerging adulthood.

Following these considerations, the current study aimed to conduct a comprehensive review of the existing literature to delve deeper insights into the psychosocial effects of romantic breakups during emerging adulthood. To better understand the concept under analysis and accurately capture its associated effects, Erikson's psychosocial theory (Erikson 1959; Newman and Newman 2020) and Arnett's development theory (Arnett 2000; Murray and Arnett 2019) were used. In broad terms, psychosocial adjustment refers to the psychosocial accommodation of a person to a life-altering event or transition (Anderson et al. 2002). Defined more specifically as a balanced mental, social and emotional state of an individual, psychosocial adjustment encompasses a diverse range of indices of psychological health. As human beings develop in complex environments, there are multivariate determinants of psychosocial adjustment that researchers must consider (Eiroa-Orosa 2020; Murray and Arnett 2019). According to Erikson (1959)'s theory, psychosocial functioning includes domains based on the major tasks during a specific period of life, constituting the content of development, that is, the important issues people face as their lives progress, such as how to define themselves, their relationships with others and what to do with their lives (Arnett 2000; Murray and Arnett 2019). During the period of development under analysis, identity and intimacy are the major developmental tasks (Erikson 1959; Montgomery 2005). Thus, this study focused more specifically on examining evidence related to psychological health and evidence related to psychosocial development, with a particular emphasis on aspects of identity and intimacy. In light of these considerations, the present study presents several hypotheses to guide the exploration of the impact of romantic breakups on both psychological health and psychosocial development (see Table 1). By testing these hypotheses, the study aims to provide a more nuanced understanding of the psychosocial effects of romantic breakups during the critical period of emerging adulthood, contributing to a more comprehensive view of this phenomenon.

2 | Materials and Methods

A systematic review was conducted in accordance with the Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses guidelines (PRISMA; Moher et al. 2009). Prior to the review, the protocol was submitted to PROSPERO—a global prospective register for review protocols (registration number: 315873).

2.1 | Eligibility Criteria

The review included studies of samples' mean age between 18 and 29 years who had experienced a romantic breakup. The main outcome under investigation was the psychosocial adjustment after a romantic breakup during emerging adulthood. To

refine and delineate precisely the intricate concept, psychosocial theories (Erikson 1959; Murray and Arnett 2019; Newman and Newman 2020) were employed, and specific social and emotional dimensions were incorporated into the search strategy.

Literature and scoping reviews were excluded, together with studies conducted on adolescents (sample mean age under 18 years), adults and elderly people (sample mean age over 30 years). Studies focusing on other forms of loss unrelated to romantic breakups or to the emerging period of life (e.g., divorce, death, parent/family separation and marital breakups) were excluded due to additional dimensions associated with such events. Finally, studies investigating other components of psychosocial functioning (e.g., cognitive and behavioural dimensions) were also excluded.

2.2 | Data Sources and Search Strategy

A systematic keyword-based search was undertaken using the bibliographic datasets of EBSCO Academic Search Ultimate, PsycINFO, PsycArticles, EMBASE, Web of Science (ISI), PubMed and Psychology & Behavioural Sciences Collection.

The search string consisted of a combination of subject headings (Academic Search Ultimate, APA, Psychology and Behavioural Sciences Collection and MeSH terms) and free text based on previous literature in the field (keywords) to reflect indexing differences between datasets. Guided by the PICO approach, keywords related to population (e.g., 'emerging adulthood') were combined with words related to indicator (e.g., 'romantic breakup') and outcome (e.g., 'psychosocial functioning' [MeSH]). A detailed search strategy is provided in Data S1. The literature search was limited to papers published in English-language peer-reviewed journals from January 2000 to December 2024.

2.3 | Data Selection and Data Analysis

Two reviewers performed systematic electronic research in each dataset to extract the individual studies. Although one independent researcher extracted the data from the eligible included studies, as well as identified and removed all the duplicate studies, the other researcher cross-checked the extracted data. Final sources were independently assessed for eligibility through a two-step process. The first screening was performed based on titles and abstracts, whereas the second screening was retrieved on full-text papers. When the full texts were unavailable, the authors were contacted twice. After each screening, the two authors systematically compared their results, discussed discrepancies, and negotiated a decision. Study screening was conducted using the online software Covidence (Veritas Health Innovation Ltd 2016). Data extraction included study name, authors, country, year of publication, journal name, sampling method, and sample size, population characteristics (e.g., age, gender, and comorbidities) and outcomes (independent and dependent variables). The present study also conducted a comprehensive meta-analysis, synthesizing the findings from three analyses identified in the systematic review, to provide a consolidated understanding of the posttraumatic growth between women and men. We reported the weighted mean differences

TABLE 1 | Hypotheses of the study.

	Hypothesis	Description
Hypothesis 1	Breakups will be associated with negative psychological health outcomes.	Negative psychological health as higher levels of breakup distress, depression and anxiety (e.g., Chung et al. 2003) Negative psychological outcomes are also associated with lower levels of general health and satisfaction with life (e.g., Samios et al. 2014).
Hypothesis 2	Breakups will be associated with changes in psychosocial developmental outcomes.	Psychosocial developmental outcomes as personal growth and changes in identity, self-concept, intimacy and self-esteem Identity, related to changes in the self, and intimacy, related to the development of future relationships (e.g., Tashiro and Frazier 2003)
Hypothesis 3	The psychological impact of a breakup will decrease over time, whereas psychosocial developmental outcomes will increase or remain more stable.	Psychological effects, such as anxiety and depression, tend to decrease gradually (e.g., Sbarra and Emery 2005), whereas developmental changes, as personal growth or identity and intimacy changes, exhibit greater consistency over time or manifest later (e.g., Barber and Cooper 2014).
Hypothesis 4	Socio-demographic factors will be associated with both psychological health and psychosocial developmental outcomes.	Socio-demographic factors as gender and age, indicate that women and younger participants have a stronger impact on both psychological and developmental effects (e.g., Boelen and Van den Hout 2010; Moller et al. 2003).
Hypothesis 5	Contextual factors will be associated with both psychological health and psychosocial developmental outcomes.	Contextual factors as initiator status, shorter time since breakup or greater relationship duration have a stronger impact on both psychological and developmental effects (e.g., Brunson et al. 2019; Palacio-González et al. 2017).
Hypothesis 6	Individual factors will be associated with both psychological health and psychosocial developmental outcomes.	Individual factors as attachment anxiety and adverse childhood maltreatment have a stronger impact on both psychological and developmental effects (e.g., Boelen and Reijntjes 2008; Chung and Hunt 2014).
Hypothesis 7	Psychological mechanisms will be associated with both psychological health and psychosocial developmental outcomes.	Psychological mechanisms as emotion-focused coping, social support and emotional regulation have a stronger impact on both psychological and developmental effects (e.g., Chung and Hunt 2014).
Hypothesis 8	Individual and mechanism factors will have a more significant impact over time than contextual factors.	Individual factors have a greater influence on how individuals process breakups in the long term compared to contextual factors (e.g., Palacio-González et al. 2017).
Hypothesis 9	Coping mechanisms will mediate the relationship between breakups and psychosocial effects.	Adaptive coping strategies as cognitive reappraisal or emotional regulation will decrease the psychosocial impact, whereas inadapative coping strategies will amplify the impact of breakups (e.g., Studley and Chung 2015).

with their corresponding 95% confidence intervals and effect size. Data analysis was performed using the Statistical Package for Social Sciences (SPSS, 29.0) and R software.

2.4 | Risk of Bias Assessment

The included studies were systematically assessed for possible risk of bias (RoB) with a tool specifically developed for assessing seven quality criteria (Shepherd et al. 2006). This tool is particularly well-suited for diverse methodological approaches used in non-intervention studies, making it pertinent to this systematic review due to the diverse nature and methods employed in the included studies. Each study received a score ranging from

zero to seven, corresponding to the number of criteria it met. All studies employing qualitative interviews with a score of 4 out of 7, as well as those without a qualitative interview but with a score of 4 out of 6, were included in the review. The quality assessment was independently conducted by two authors, and all disagreements were resolved through consensus. A Cohen's kappa statistic was calculated to document agreement between reviewers (McHugh 2012).

Information extracted from the studies was organized based on study outcomes and measures. A systematic narrative review was presented and summarized the characteristics and results of all included studies, allowing the discussion of the selected studies' similarities and differences.

3 | Results

3.1 | Studies Selection

The initial search process using the bibliographic datasets resulted in 590 records (396 in EBSCOhost, 90 in Web of Science [ISI] and 104 in PubMed). Before the extraction, 134 duplicates were excluded, resulting in 456 records for screening. Based on titles and abstracts, 349 records were considered irrelevant by the two independent reviewers. Full-text papers were obtained for the remaining 107 records undergoing the second screening. In this second round, an additional 63 records were excluded due to the following reasons: age criteria ($n=3$); unrelated to breakup ($n=17$); unrelated to psychosocial adjustment according to study criterion (e.g., reasons to breakup, cognitive and behaviour dimensions, $n=20$); other design methods ($n=14$), such as including review ($n=1$), case study ($n=6$), intervention study ($n=1$), scale validation ($n=3$), grounded theory ($n=1$) and neurophysiological study ($n=3$); other languages ($n=3$); not a peer-reviewed article ($n=4$); and unavailable article ($n=2$). After full-text screening, a total of 44 records met the inclusion criteria of this systematic review. Finally, the author included 23 records by examining the reference lists of the included records. Despite our efforts to encompass diverse terms in defining the indicator and refining the outcome of this review (see Data S1), it remained challenging due to the wide range of terms and variations in terminology. For example, some studies used terms as 'rupture' or 'dissolution of dating relationships'. Additionally, some studies lacked detailed participant information, referring to them as 'participants' or just 'students'. This process resulted in a final total sample of 67 studies. The study selection process is described in Figure 1.

A total of 20 studies were excluded from the analysis based on the RoB assessment, resulting in a final sample of 47 studies. RoB results are illustrated in Data S2.

The Kappa statistic for agreement on the bias assessment between the two reviewers (CS and JGF) was 0.75, indicating a good level of agreement. Disagreement most frequently arose in relation to quality criterion (v) 'A clear description of methodology, including systematic data collection methods' and criteria (iii) 'A clear description of context which includes detail on factors important for interpreting results' and (iv) 'A clear description of sample'. The reason for disagreement was the perceived incoherence and incompleteness. The main sources of bias were criterion (iii) 'A clear description of context which includes detail on factors important for interpreting results' (not fulfilled by 54 studies) and criterion (v) 'A clear description of methodology, including systematic data collection methods' (not fulfilled by 40 studies). Some studies did not include detailed demographic information or statistical parameters, showing significant gaps in study methodology and limiting the reliability of the data.

3.2 | Studies Characteristics

The included studies were published between 2001 and 2024, with a significant number of studies published after 2010 ($n=34$, 72%) and the major incidence in the years 2022 ($n=5$, 10.6%)

and 2020 ($n=4$, 8.5%). The studies were broadly geographically distributed for America ($n=30$), Europe ($n=10$), Asia ($n=6$) and Oceania countries ($n=1$, cf. Figure 2). Thirty-six of the studies used a cross-sectional design, whereas the remaining 11 were longitudinal.

Thirty-five of the studies were quantitative studies and used self-reports to assess the psychosocial effects of a romantic breakup. Three used interview-based reports or other methods, featuring a qualitative approach. Four studies used both quantitative and experimental procedures, and one study used both experimental and qualitative procedures. The remaining four used a mixed approach.

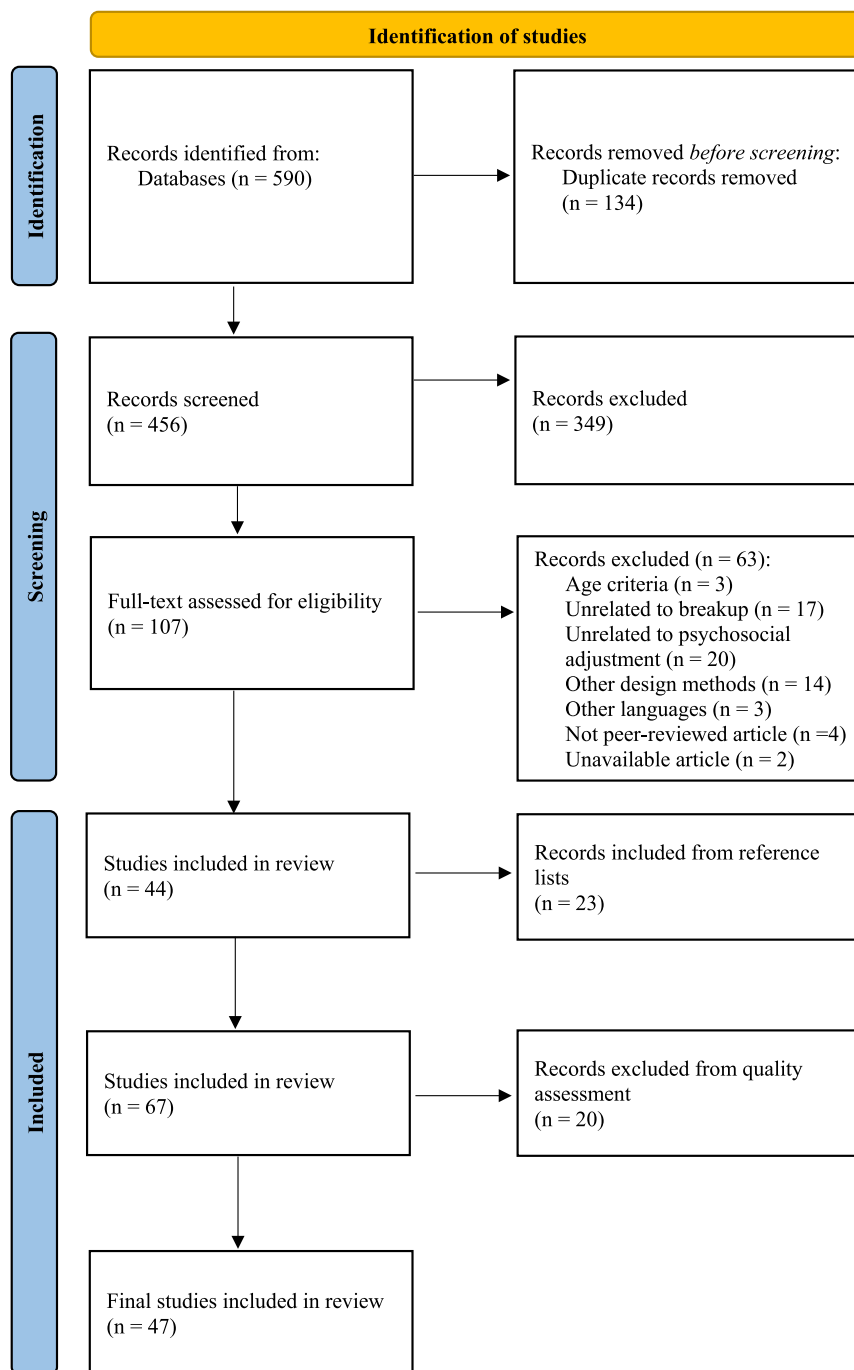
Sample sizes ranged from 21 to 1295 ($M=296$, $SD=265.9$), resulting in a total of 13,912 participants in the 47 included studies. There is a significant number of studies with sample sizes smaller than 200 ($n=28$). Specifically, 16 studies had sample sizes under 100, and 21 studies included more than 200 individuals. The majority of study participants were female, with an average of 66.86%. Additionally, 46% of participants had initiated the breakup, with only one study reporting a higher percentage of partner-initiated breakups. The mean age ranged from 18 to 27, with an overall mean age of 21.22 years ($SD=2.18$). The average time since the romantic breakup was 10 months, though there was a lot of variation, with some studies including only a few weeks after breakup ($M=9.95$, $SD=948$, range 0.36–38.38 months). The average length of the relationship prior to the breakup was 19 months ($M=18.93$, $SD=6.98$, range 9.55–36.85 months). Table 2 provides an overview of the characteristics and main findings of the included studies.

3.3 | Empirical Evidence of Psychosocial Effects

3.3.1 | Hypothesis 1. Breakups will be associated with negative psychological health outcomes

Among all studies, psychological health received the most empirical support in the field: 23 studies provided evidence of psychological and emotional distress (e.g., Marshall et al. 2013), 16 studies focused on depressive and anxious symptoms (e.g., Boelen and Reijntjes 2008), and 15 studies showed significant and diverse effects on general health (e.g., Chung et al. 2003). The included studies measured psychological health by using 32 different instruments (see Table 3). It is noteworthy that no instruments have been specifically designed and validated for postbreakup psychological and emotional experiences, leading to concerns regarding the reliability and accuracy of these measures in capturing the nuances of romantic dissolutions. For example, the most widely used instrument in the field, the Breakup Distress Scale (BDS; Field et al. 2009), was adapted from the Inventory of Complicated Grief (ICG; Prigerson et al. 1995), a measure originally designed to assess a different construct.

3.3.1.1 | Distress. The findings suggest that breakups are associated with a range of negative psychological health indices. In general, individuals who experienced a breakup reported higher levels of distress compared to nonclinical samples, such as medical students and those who remained in the same



From: Page MJ, McKenzie JE, Bossuyt PM, Boutron I, Hoffmann TC, Mulrow CD, et al. The PRISMA 2020 statement: an updated guideline for reporting systematic reviews. *BMJ* 2021;372:n71. doi: 10.1136/bmj.n71

FIGURE 1 | Flow chart of studies included in the systematic review.

relationship or were single (Chung et al. 2003; Palacio-González et al. 2016; Rhoades et al. 2011). No significant differences were found when compared to clinical samples of individuals who had experienced bereavement or stress (Boelen and Van den Hout 2010), except for intrusion levels, which were lower than those in a stress clinic sample (Chung et al. 2002). Participants commonly reported high levels of intrusive thoughts and avoidance behaviours (ranging from 9% to 66%), including persistent thoughts (25%–66%, Chung et al. 2002, 2003, Hawley et al. 2015; Studley and Chung 2015), strong emotional waves (25%–35%),

sleep disturbances, such as trouble falling asleep or having dreams about the breakup (10%–14%), strong emotions often feeling as if the breakup had not happened or was unreal (15%), a sense of emotional numbness or detachment toward the dissolution of the relationship (10%) and engaging in behaviours that involve attempts to remove the breakup from memory, such as avoidance of reminders (25%–66%; Chung et al. 2002, 2003). A similar pattern across the studies showed that intrusive thoughts were more prevalent than avoidance behaviours (Chung et al. 2003; Studley and Chung 2015). Although the emotional

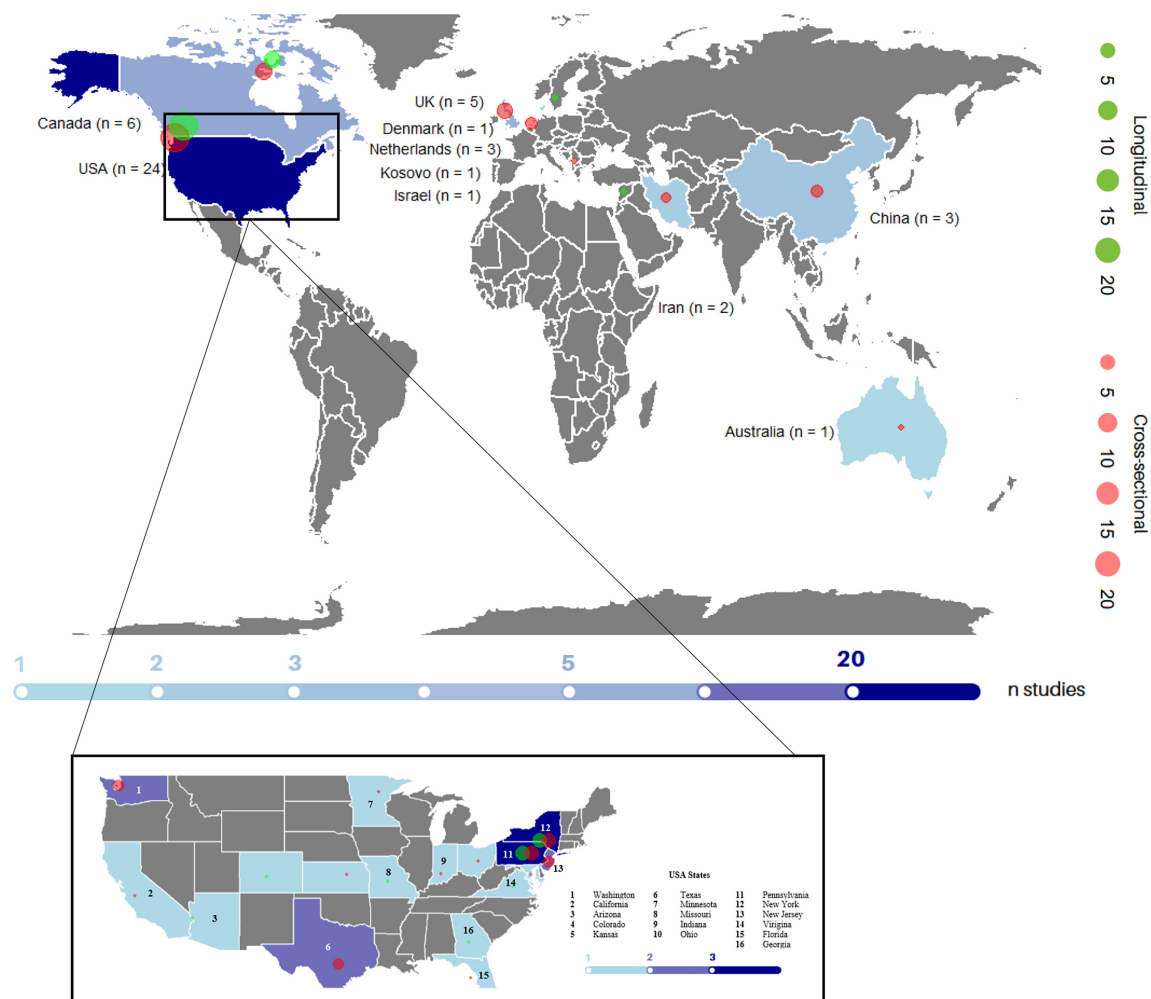


FIGURE 2 | Number of studies per country and design used. *Note:* The size of the circles corresponds to the number of studies using the specific study design: red for cross-sectional and green for longitudinal.

impact of breakups varied across studies depending on the measured outcome, the reported percentages remained significantly high. For instance, Hawley et al. (2015) reported that 50% of participants experienced feelings of anger, with 15% reporting moderate to high levels.

3.3.1.2 | Depression. The results also showed that people feel more depressed after a breakup compared to the general student population (Palacio-González et al. 2016) and more depressed and anxious than the non-clinical sample (Boelen and Reijntjes 2008). Even when participants reported low levels of depressive symptoms, they showed more depression and rumination compared to people who had not experienced a breakup (O'Sullivan et al. 2019). Sex differences were also found, with female participants having slightly higher mean scores on depression and hostility compared to college women, whereas male participants scored lower, although these differences were not statistically significant (Tashiro and Frazier 2003). Our findings underscore that breakup distress is a significant predictor of depressive symptoms (Akbari et al. 2022). The overall impact of the breakup, including both emotional intrusion and avoidance, was positively associated with negative indicators of adjustment, encompassing both depression and anxiety (Boelen and Reijntjes 2008; Chung et al. 2003; Samios et al. 2014).

However, for individuals who found the breakup more distressing, benefit finding was correlated with less depression, whereas it was not significant for those who found it less distressing (Samios et al. 2014). Surprisingly, Drew et al. (2004) found no significant main effect of relationship loss on depression, indicating that the emotional impact of a breakup on depressive symptoms was not directly influenced by the fact of the relationship ending. Instead, the impact of self-loss after a breakup emerged as a significant factor, with higher levels correlated with greater dysphoria.

3.3.1.3 | General Health. Concerning general health, about half of the participants scored above the cutoff for psychiatric cases on the General Health Questionnaire (GHQ; Chung et al. 2002, 2003; Studley and Chung 2015). The impact of the breakup, both intrusive thoughts and avoidance behaviours, was positively associated with general health (Chung et al. 2002, 2003; Wrape et al. 2016). The most commonly reported feelings were heartbroken (32.1%) and devastated (30.5%; Studley and Chung 2015). Anxiety is the most prevalent concern, followed by social dysfunction and somatic problems, whereas depression appeared less problematic in three studies (Chung et al. 2002, 2003; Studley and Chung 2015). However, Fang et al. (2018) found lower social dysfunction

TABLE 2 | Characteristics and main findings of the included studies.

Authors (year)	Country	Study design	n (n female)	Age M years (SD)	Outcome measure(s)	Main findings
Akbari et al. (2022)	Iran	Cross-sectional, quantitative	347 (236)	22.62 (3.69)	Enright self-forgiveness (ESFI) Self-compassion (SCS-SF) Beck depression Inventory (BDI)	BDS as a predictor of BDI, ESFI, and SCS ESFI and SCS associated with BDI SCS mediated the mediating role of ESFI in BDS and BDI
Ayduk et al. (2001)	USA	Longitudinal, quantitative	178 (178)	18.5 (0.57)	Beck depression Inventory (BDI)	High rejection and noninitiators had more BDI
Barber and Cooper (2014)	USA	Longitudinal, mixed	170 (112)	18.3 (na)	Interview (distress, anger, appearance self-esteem and social self-esteem)	Distress and anger decreased over 8 months and social self-esteem increased No gender effects, but men had higher appearance self-esteem after a month Noninitiators and longer relationships with more distress, anger and self-esteem
Boelen and Reijntjes (2008)	The Netherlands	Cross-sectional, quantitative	79 (66)	21.5 (2.5)	Complicated grief (ICG-r) Symptom checklist (SCL-90)	Single, non-initiation, more commitment, less time since breakup, suddenness, attachment anxiety and grief cognitions related to higher ICG. Dating, neuroticism, attachment anxiety and grief cognitions related to SCL
Boelen and Van den Hout (2010)	The Netherlands	Cross-sectional, quantitative and experimental	78 (69)	21.3 (2.1)	Complicated grief (ICG-r)	Age, initiation status, suddenness, time since breakup, dating, commitment, relationship duration and IOS related to ICG
Brody et al. (2020)	USA	Cross-sectional, mixed	234 (181)	19.41 (1.67)	Open-ended question (postbreakup adjustment)	Keeping behaviour associated with postbreakup adjustment for high/moderate deleting behaviour. No mediation of nostalgia between deleting and adjustment.
Brumbaugh and Fraley (2015)	USA	Cross-sectional, quantitative	77 (60) 236 (125)	20 (3.19) 21.71 (5.63)	Well-being (nv) Rosenberg self-esteem Specific interpersonal trust	Dating and dating sooner related to adjustment: higher confidence, self-esteem, well-being, and trust, lower lingering feelings for ex-partners
Brunson et al. (2019)	USA	Cross-sectional, quantitative	242 (206)	22.06 (3.97)	Investment model scale (IMS) Relationship assessment scale Inclusion of other in self (IOS) Schema change	49% positive changes in self, partner, and relationship schemas; 19% no changes; 70% partner changes, 69% relationship changes, and 58% self-changes. Dating, past commitment, time since breakup and current relationship quality not related to changes
Chung et al. (2002)	UK	Cross-sectional, quantitative	60 (36)	21.77 (5.38)	Impact of event scale (IES) General health (GHQ-28)	Anxiety caused most concern, followed by social dysfunction and somatic problems. IES related to GHQ. Negative self-esteem predicted avoidance (7.7%) and GHQ (20.1%) Neuroticism as a predictor of IES (7.4%)

(Continues)

TABLE 2 | (Continued)

Authors (year)	Country	Study design	n (n female)	Age M years (SD)	Outcome measure(s)	Main findings
Chung et al. (2003)	UK	Cross-sectional, quantitative	88 (53)	22.75 (6.76)	Impact of event scale (IES) General health (GHQ-28)	Escape avoidance, distancing, seeking social support and planful problem-solving as predictors of IES (36%). Escape avoidance and accepting responsibility related to intrusion (26%). Escape avoidance and distancing related to avoidance (25%). Escape avoidance related to GHQ (38%).
Chung and Hunt (2014)	UK	Cross-sectional, quantitative	189 (142)	26.06	Impact of event scale (IES) General health (GHQ-28)	In love with ex, noninitiators, n of breakups, PTSD and difficulty describing feelings related to IES intrusion (33%). Income levels, time since breakup, PTSD and suppressed anxiety related to IES avoidance (19%). PTSD and difficulty identifying feelings related to GHQ (25%).
Dardis (2003)	USA	Cross-sectional, quantitative	821 (488)	19 (1.58)	Rumination, emotional flooding (nv)	Denial coping and initiator status related to emotional flooding and rumination
Drew et al. (2004)	USA	Cross-sectional, quantitative	107 (73) 88 (61)	21 19.7	Beck Depression Inventory (BDI) Dependency (DEQ)	No significant effect of relationship loss on BDI and DEQ Self-loss related to higher BDI and DEQ. Sex effect on DEQ No mediation of self-silencing between sex and BDI
Eisma et al. (2022)	The Netherlands	Cross-sectional, quantitative and experimental	62 (47)	20.89 (2.50)	Utrecht grief rumination (UGRS) Traumatic grief (TGI-SR)	Time since breakup related to higher distress Anxious attachment related to rumination Rumination, yearning and automatic approach related to higher breakup distress
Fang et al. (2018)	China	Cross-sectional, quantitative	180 (111)	21.38 (2.64)	General health (GHQ-28)	Assertion of autonomy related to less GHQ, after controlling for abuse and violence severity Negative self-cognitions and self-blame related to more GHQ Mediation of these cognitions between PTSS and GHQ Moderation of the assertion of autonomy in the mediating effect
Francoeur et al. (2020)	Canada	Cross-sectional, quantitative	483 (392)	22.05	Child and youth resilience (CYRM) Brief symptom (BSI)	Childhood maltreatment related to lower CYRM and higher BSI and distress Mediation of emotional regulation and mentalization Emotional regulation related to CYRM (9.2%), BSI (12.9%) and distress (20.3%) Mentalization related to CYRM and BSI (5%)

(Continues)

TABLE 2 | (Continued)

Authors (year)	Country	Study design	<i>n</i> (<i>n</i> female)	Age <i>M</i> years (SD)	Outcome measure(s)	Main findings
Gehl et al. (2024)	Canada	Longitudinal, quantitative	196 (163)	21 (2.2)	Brief Symptom Inventory (BSI)	Self-punishment predicted anxiety over time Accommodation coping and self-punishment predicted depression Mediation of self-punishment between attachment and BSI Mediation of accommodation between attachment and depression
Geng et al. (2022)	China	Cross-sectional, quantitative	869 (338)	19.48 (1.15)	Breakup distress scale (BDS)	Males with more BDS Machiavellianism related to more BDS; mediation of self-concealment
Hawley et al. (2015)	USA	Cross-sectional, quantitative	445 (320)	19.31 (1.22)	State-trait anger expression Impact of event scale (IES)	Relationship duration, time since breakup and sacred loss/desecration related to anger and distress Full mediation of sacred loss/desecration between sexual activity and outcomes
Heshmati et al. (2022)	Iran	Cross-sectional, quantitative	239 (121)	24.11 (15.29)	Romantic breakup grief (RBGI)	Attachment closeness and anxiety, childhood maltreatment and emotional suppression related to RBGI No significant effect for attachment dependency Mediation of emotional suppression
Kansky and Allen (2018)	USA	Longitudinal, quantitative	307 (172)	22.80 (0.96)	State-trait anger expression (STAI) Adult behaviour checklist Conflict Tactics Scale Autonomy-undermining behaviour Relationship Assessment Scale Intimate competence	Initiator predicted peer-reported internalizing behaviours and behaviours undermining autonomy. Understanding breakup reasons related to internalizing symptoms and conflict, relationship satisfaction and intimate competence in later relationships
Lewandowski et al. (2006)	USA	Cross-sectional, qualitative and experimental	59 (39) 63 (39) 55 (36)	21 19 20	Self-concept (nv)	Self-expansion related to more negative effects of self-concept and a greater loss of identity Relationship closeness related to a greater loss of identity. Emphasizing self-expanding aspects related to a less diverse self-concept Emphasizing close times related to a more diverse self-concept

(Continues)

TABLE 2 | (Continued)

Authors (year)	Country	Study design	n (n female)	Age M years (SD)	Outcome measure(s)	Main findings
Lewandowski and Bizzoco (2007)	USA	Cross-sectional, quantitative	155 (116)	19	Loss and rediscovery of self (nv) Postdissolution growth (PTGI)	Self-expansion (3%), rediscovery of self, loss of self (10%), emotions (41%) and positive reinterpretation (3%) related to PTGI Meditation of rediscovery and self-loss and emotions Self-expansion related rediscovery and loss of self
Liang and van Horn (2020)	China	Cross-sectional, quantitative	428 (307)	19.36 (1.59)	Self-esteem scale Center for Epidemiologic Studies Depression Scale (CES-D)	Dating related to less CES; Moderation of sexual conservativeness Not mediation of self-esteem Sexual conservativeness related to less CES Nonsignificant for self-esteem
Marshall et al. (2013)	UK	Cross-sectional, quantitative	411 (273)	23.47 (6.75)	Breakup Distress Scale (BDS) Posttraumatic growth (PTGI)	Sex, attachment anxiety and avoidance related to BDS Sex and attachment avoidance related to PTGI Mediation of BDS
			473 (393)	21.36 (5.49)		Attachment anxiety and avoidance related to BDS and PTGI Sex related to BDS Rebound, brooding and reflection related to PTGI Mediation of BDS, brooding and reflection
Moller et al. (2003)	USA	Cross-sectional, quantitative	261 (159)	20.62 (2.00)	UCLA loneliness scale Beck Hopelessness Scale (BHS) Hopkins symptom checklist (HSC) Perceived stress scale (PSS)	Sex, time since breakup (6%), confidence, relationship as secondary (56%), attachment to peer (8%) and social connectedness (9%) related to loneliness Confidence, need for approval (36%), attachment to peer (6%) and social connectedness (3%) related to BHS Time since breakup (6%), confidence, relationship as secondary, need for approval, preoccupation with relationships (33%) and social connectedness (4%) related to HSC Time since breakup (3%), confidence, preoccupation with relationships (31%) and social connectedness (5%) related to PSS
O'Sullivan et al. (2019)	Canada	Longitudinal, quantitative	886 (549)	20.7	Rosenberg self-esteem Short Grit Scale Life Orientation Test—Revised Beck Depression Inventory (BDI-II) Ruminative responses scale	Sex related to self-esteem, optimism, BDI and rumination. Dating related to self-esteem Self-esteem, grit and optimism related to BDI and rumination

(Continues)

TABLE 2 | (Continued)

Authors (year)	Country	Study design	n (n female)	Age M years (SD)	Outcome measure(s)	Main findings
Owenz and Fowers (2019)	USA	Longitudinal, quantitative	599 (425)	20.48 (2.11)	Life Orientation Test—Revised Posttraumatic growth (PTGI) Impact of event scale (IES)	Sex and PTSD related to PTGI PTSD related to IES and optimism
Palacio-González et al. (2017)	Canada	Longitudinal, quantitative	148 (115)	20 (3.4)	Posttraumatic growth (PTGI) Breakup distress scale (BDS)	Brooding (3%), relationship duration, desire for dissolution (6%), and intrusive rumination (5%) predicted BDS T1. Brooding (6%) and deliberate rumination (7%) predicted PTGI T1 BDS T1 (69%), reflection and brooding (4%) predicted BDS T2 PTGI T1 (28%) deliberate rumination (14%) and deliberate T2×intrusive T1 (5%) predicted PTGI T2
Palacio-González et al. (2017)	Denmark	Cross-sectional, mixed	91 (76)	20.13 (3.47)	Breakup distress scale (BDS) Beck Depression Inventory (BDI-II)	BDI higher than the general student population Desire for breakup related to BDI Positive and negative relationship memories and content related to BDS and BDI
Park et al. (2011)	USA	Cross-sectional, quantitative	312 (245)	22.1 (5.4)	Contingency of self- worth (CSW) Multiple Affect Adjective Check List (MAACL-R)	Relationship CSW, sex, noninitiation, partner contribution to problems and relationship duration related to emotional distress (40%) Self-esteem, rejection sensitivity, dismissive and preoccupied attachment explained 42% of CSW.
Perilloux and Buss (2008)	USA	Cross-sectional, quantitative	199 (101)	20.58 (2.32)	Depression, rumination, self-esteem, unable to acquire mate, sadness, anger and threats of suicide (nv)	Noninitiators with more depression, rumination, crying or pleading with their ex-partners, suicide threats and less self-esteem Felt more sad, angry, confused, shocked and jealous Female noninitiators with more intense sadness, confusion, and fear Male initiators with more happiness and indifference Female initiators with more rumination, crying and pleading with ex-partner
Primeau et al. (2013)	USA	Cross-sectional, qualitative	41 (26)	20.76 (1.74)	Writing task	The most common loss was the loss of someone they could confide in and depend on. The most common gain was related to freedom: space/time to focus on self, school and other relationships.
Randelović and Goljović (2020)	Kosovo	Cross-sectional, quantitative	387 (320)	23.90 (4.22)	Breakup distress scale (BDS)	Initiator, COPE problem and avoidance and anxiety attachment related to BDS (26%)

(Continues)

TABLE 2 | (Continued)

Authors (year)	Country	Study design	n (n female)	Age M years (SD)	Outcome measure(s)	Main findings
Reimer and Estrada (2020)	USA	Cross-sectional, quantitative	254 (165)	18.57 (1.10)	Complicated grief (ICG)	Gender, time since breakup, relationship duration (9.3%), closeness (22.6%) and stigma (43%) related to ICG No interaction between closeness and stigma
Rhoades et al. (2011)	USA	Longitudinal, quantitative	1295 (842)	25.57 (4.81)	Mood and anxiety symptom questionnaire (MASQ) Satisfaction with life scale	Breakup individuals with more psychological distress and less life satisfaction compared to those in the same relationship No significant prediction for psychological distress Lived together, plans for marriage, relationship quality and dating related to life satisfaction over time
Saffrey and Ehrenberg (2007)	Canada	Cross-sectional, quantitative	231 (147)	19.12 (1.72)	Mood and anxiety symptom questionnaire (MASQ)	Sex, anxiety attachment, dwelling, reflection, regret, relationship preoccupation, and current dating explained general adjustment Mediation of regret, dwelling and relationship preoccupation between anxiety attachment and general adjustment
Samios et al. (2014)	Australia	Cross-sectional, quantitative	140 (102)	21.57 (2.75)	Perceived benefit scales Depression, anxiety and stress	Initiator, current dating (9%), person attribution (8%), benefit finding and IES (11%) related to depression Sex, other and environmental attribution (8%) and IES related to anxiety Benefit finding and IES (18%) related to satisfaction with life Age, current dating (9%), benefit finding and IES (16%) related to positive affect Interaction of benefit finding and IES on depression
Sbarra and Emery (2005)	USA	Longitudinal, mixed	58 (48)	18.9 (1.1)	Anger and sadness (nv) Impact of event scale (IES) Mood and anxiety symptom questionnaire (MASQ)	Decline of high sadness over time Decline of anger particularly in the first 5 days Contact with ex, emotional intrusion, fearful and secure attachment and self-blame related to sadness Secure and dismissing attachment related with more anger Avoidant coping and sadness predicted more disturbance (46%) Self-blame and sadness predicted IES (47%) Secure attachment, self-blame and relief predicted positive affect (42%)

(Continues)

TABLE 2 | (Continued)

Authors (year)	Country	Study design	n (n female)	Age M years (SD)	Outcome measure(s)	Main findings
Shulman and Yonatan-Leus (2024)	Israel	Longitudinal, quantitative	100 (66)	27.44 (0.75)	Brief Symptom Inventory (BSI) Experiences in Close Relationships (ECR) Beck Depression Inventory (BDI-II) Romantic competence interview (nv)	BDS age 20 predicted BDI Sex, anxiety age 20 and BDS change 20 to 28 predicted BSI Anxiety age 20 predicted avoidance attachment Sex, anxiety age 20 and BDS change predicted preoccupied attachment Parental marital status, anxiety age 20, BDS age 20, BDS change and PTGI predicted romantic competence Mediation of PTGI between BDS change and BSI
Slotter and Gardner (2012)	USA	Cross-sectional, quantitative and experimental	66 (35)	18.9 (0.7)	Self-concept confusion (nv) Self-concept change (nv)	Anxiety attachment related to more self-concept change and self-concept confusion No moderation of avoidance or gender Mediation of self-concept change between anxiety and self-concept confusion
Spielmann et al. (2009)	Canada	Cross-sectional, quantitative and experimental	149 (113)	19.65	Positive and negative affect	Anxiety attachment related to positive and negative affect
Studley and Chung (2015)	UK	Cross-sectional, quantitative	83 (59) 83 (58) 187 (156)	19.46 18.89 25.7 (6.49)	Impact of event scale (IES-R) General health (GHQ-28)	In the optimism condition, anxiety attachment related to less attachment to ex-partners. In the pessimism, anxiety related to more Romantic feelings about ex (22%), PTSD (7%), emotion and problem coping (13%) related to IES Romantic feelings about ex (13%), PTSD (7%) and emotion coping (6%) related to GHQ Mediation of emotion coping between PTSD and both IES and GHQ Mediation of problem coping between PTSD and IE No mediation of PTGI between PTSD and GHQ
Tashiro and Frazier (2003)	USA	Cross-sectional, qualitative	92 (69)	20	Posttraumatic growth (PTGI) Brief symptom (BSI)	Five positive changes that might improve their future romantic relationships The most common person change was feeling stronger, more self-confident, more independent and better off emotionally The most common relational positive change was having gained relational wisdom. Dating (7%) and neuroticism (23%) related to BSI Agreeableness (12%) and sex (8%) to PTGI

(Continues)

TABLE 2 | (Continued)

Authors (year)	Country	Study design	n (n female)	Age M years (SD)	Outcome measure(s)	Main findings
Wang et al. (2024)	USA	Longitudinal, quantitative	351 (223)	25.48 (5.36)	Beck Depression Inventory (BDI-II)	Social support and neuroticism predicted BDI T0 but not BDI T1
Washburn-Busk et al. (2020)	USA	Cross-sectional, qualitative	21 (19)	21.6 (2.99)		Underdeveloped or unstable identity as the most prevalent that impairs decision-making resilience Undefined values, low confidence and self-esteem, jealousy and being codependent negatively related to decision-making postbreakup Therapy and exploring desired partner characteristics are recommended to enhance decision-making and cope with breakup grief
Wrape et al. (2016)	USA	Cross-sectional, quantitative	132 (88)	19.89	Hopkins symptom (HSCL)	Age, sex (5%), initiator (6%), avoidance and intrusive rumination (33%) related to HSCL Moderation of gender and rumination explained 42% of HSCL.

levels compared to somatic problems, anxiety and depression. Despite the sample differences across these studies, no clear pattern emerged. Even so, one study identified participants as less extroverted and less neurotic (Chung et al. 2002); another found using more emotion-focused rather than problem-focused coping strategies (Studley and Chung 2015), whereas another demonstrated greater assessment quality (Fang et al. 2018). When assessed by friends, peers of female participants reported greater internalizing symptoms (Kansky and Allen 2018).

The impact of the breakup is also negatively associated with all psychological health indicators, including lower satisfaction with life and positive affect (Samios et al. 2014). Life satisfaction decreased for both genders after the breakup (28.6%), with individuals expressing lower levels compared to those who were in a relationship (Rhoades et al. 2011; Samios et al. 2014). No differences were found for optimism and grit, but this conclusion is drawn from a single study (O'Sullivan et al. 2019).

3.3.2 | Hypothesis 2. Breakups will be associated with changes in psychosocial developmental outcomes

The findings provide evidence that breakups are associated with personal growth and significant changes in self-concept and relational patterns, both positive and negative, supporting the hypothesis that breakups contribute to changes in psychosocial development. A total of six studies explored posttraumatic growth (e.g., Marshall et al. 2013), whereas 13 studies focused on diverse changes in identity dimension and eight explored intimacy dimension (e.g., Kansky and Allen 2018; Lewandowski et al. 2006). To assess these outcomes, researchers employed 33 different instruments (see Table 3), which reflects a broad range of constructs within psychosocial development. Unlike psychological health, where at least some validated scales were adapted, identity and intimacy dimensions lacked standardized tools, further limiting the reliability and comparability of findings across studies. This underscores the need for the development and validation of specific instruments to accurately capture self-concept and intimacy-related changes.

3.3.2.1 | Posttraumatic Growth. Despite the psychological burden of breakups, with 33% viewing the breakup as having a negative impact and 25.7% as nonsignificant, 41.3% perceived it as a positive experience (Lewandoski and Bizzoco 2007). Posttraumatic growth scores, comparable to or even higher than those observed after traumatic events, underline the transformative potential of relationship dissolution (Palacio-González et al. 2016), with 71% of individuals experiencing growth (Lewandoski and Bizzoco 2007). Specifically, participants reported greater improvements in their ability to relate to others, in comparison with other domains, such as spiritual change, appreciation of life, new possibilities and personal strength. Among these, spiritual change was the least reported, indicating that breakups can more often lead to relational and personal insights (Studley and Chung 2015). It is noteworthy that Owenz and Fowers (2019) found no significant association between experiencing a breakup and actual

TABLE 3 | Outcome measures used in the included studies.

Psychological health outcomes	Developmental outcomes
Impact of Events Scale (IES; Sundin and Horowitz 2002)	Posttraumatic Growth Inventory (PTGI; Tedeschi and Calhoun 1996)
Inventory of complicated grief (ICG; Prigerson et al. 1995)	Growth (nv)
Breakup Distress Scale (BDS; Field et al. 2009; based on ICG)	Short Grit Scale (Duckworth and Quinn 2009)
Romantic Breakup Grief Inventory (RBGI; Dehghani et al. 2011; based on Love Trauma Inventory, Rosse 1999)	Child and Youth Resilience Measure (CYRM) (Daigneault et al. 2013)
Perceived Stress Scale (PSS; Cohen et al. 1983)	Rosenberg Self-Esteem Scale (Rosenberg 1965)
Distress (nv) ^a	Self-esteem (Cast and Burke 2002, based on Rosenberg Self-esteem Scale)
Postbreakup adjustment (nv)	Self-esteem (nv) ^a
Emotional distress by Multiple Adjectives Affect Check List (MAACL-R; Zuckerman et al. 1983)	Self-concept (open-ended response)
Relationship Preoccupation Scale (RPS; Davis et al. 2003)	Rediscovery of self (nv)
Depression, Anxiety and Stress Scales (Lovibond and Lovibond 1995)	Loss of self (nv)
Beck Depression Inventory (Beck et al. 1996)	Self-concept change (nv)
Center for Epidemiologic Studies Depression Scale (CESD; Radloff 1977)	Self-concept confusion (nv)
Mood and Anxiety Symptom Questionnaire (MASQ; Watson and Clark 1991)	Self-schema (nv)
Depression, rumination, crying, pleading, threats of suicide, sadness and anger (nv)	Relationship schema (nv)
Symptom checklist-90 (SCL-90; Derogatis 1983)	Partner schema (nv)
Brief Symptom Inventory (BSI; Derogatis 1992)	Self-Compassion Scale (SCS-SF; Raes et al. 2011)
General Health Questionnaire (GHQ-28; Goldberg and Hiller 1979)	Enright Forgiveness Inventory (Subkoviak et al. 1995).
Adult Behaviour Checklist (Achenbach & Rescorla 2003)	Autonomy and Relatedness Coding System (Allen et al. 2000)
Hopkins Symptom Checklist (Green et al. 1988)	Relational Self-Worth Scale (Harter 1995)
State-Trait Anxiety Inventory (Spielberger et al. 1970)	Rebound (time)
State-Trait Anger Expression Inventory (Spielberger 1988)	Specific Interpersonal Trust Scale (Johnson-George and Swap 1982)
Anger (nv)	Relationship Assessment Scale (Hendrick et al. 1998)
Sadness and anger (daily diary)	Conflict Tactics Scale (Straus 1979)
Bradburn Affect Balance Scale (Bradburn 1969)	Closeness (Inclusion of Other in Self Scale IOS; Aron et al. 1992)
Positive and negative affect (nv)	Commitment (Investment Model Scale (IMS; Rusbult et al. 1998)
Ruminative Responses Scale (Nolen-Hoeksema 1991)	Respect for Partner Scale (Frei and Shaver 2002)
Utrecht Grief Rumination Scale (UGRS; Eisma et al. 2014)	Unable to acquire mate and interference in relationships (nv)
Well-being by Affectometer 2 (Kammann and Flett 1983)	Confidence, discomfort with closeness, need for approval, preoccupation with relationships and relationships as secondary (Feeney et al. 1994)

(Continues)

TABLE 3 | (Continued)

Psychological health outcomes	Developmental outcomes
Satisfaction with Life Scale (Diener et al. 1985)	UCLA Loneliness Scale (Russell 1996)
Optimism (Life Orientation Test—Revised; Scheier et al. 1994)	Dependency Subscale of the DEQ (Blatt et al. 1976)
The Hopelessness Scale (Beck et al. 1974)	Relationship contingency of self-worth (relationship CSW; Sanchez and Kwang 2007)
Emotional flooding and rumination (nv)	Experiences in Close (Future) Relationships (ECR; Brennan et al. 1998)
	Romantic competence interview (nv)

Abbreviation: nv, not validated.

^aTwo distinct measures assessing the same construct, specifically developed for the study.

growth when compared to those who had not experienced a breakup. However, the impact of the event was linked to both perceived and actual growth, with actual growth correlating with perceived growth. This underscores the importance of verifying how both growth and breakups were assessed. The way the experience was processed may have a greater influence on personal growth than the occurrence of the event per se. It has been observed that both positive and negative emotions (58% and 31%, respectively) played a significant role in fostering growth after the breakup, explaining 41% of the variance (Lewandoski and Bizzoco 2007). Marshall et al. (2013) also found that breakup distress can be positively associated with personal growth. Additionally, people who experienced more rediscovery of self had more personal growth after the breakup, explaining 10% of the variance. However, this effect was not significant for loss of self (Lewandoski and Bizzoco 2007).

3.3.2.2 | Identity and Intimacy. Breakup experiences are associated with significant changes across multiple domains including self (58%), partner (70%), relational (69%) and environmental schemas (Brunson et al. 2019; Tashiro and Frazier 2003). Self-schemas represent how individuals perceive and define themselves; partner schemas involve mental representations and beliefs about one's partner; relational schemas encompass cognitive and emotional frameworks that shape expectations and understanding of relationships in general (Brunson et al. 2019); and environmental schemas refer to representations about social relationships and the social environment (Tashiro and Frazier 2003). Evidence found that participants reported approximately five positive self-changes contributing to future romantic relationships, with the most common being feelings of strength, self-confidence, independence and emotional well-being. Relational wisdom and improved friendships emerged as the most prevalent positive relational and environmental changes, respectively, whereas choosing different types of partners in the future was the most prevalent positive partner-related change (Tashiro and Frazier 2003). Specifically, Brunson et al. (2019) found that changes in the partner component were associated with future relationship quality; negative partner schema changes were associated with less commitment and positive self-schema changes with greater closeness and commitment in future relationships. Furthermore, posttraumatic growth following a breakup predicted greater meaning within

romantic competence (Shulman and Yonatan-Leus 2024). Interestingly, evidence from Drew et al. (2004) showed that relationship loss was not significantly associated with emotional dependency in future relationships, whereas self-loss emerged as a significant factor. Partners of female participants who began dating after the breakup reported greater relational conflict (Kansky and Allen 2018), suggesting that the psychological impact of breakups may extend beyond the individuals directly affected. On the other hand, Slotter and Gardner (2012) showed that self-concept change was positively associated with self-concept confusion.

Research has shown that breakups appear to be associated with self-perception, self-esteem and identity stability, with both negative and positive consequences. A substantial proportion of participants exhibited self-doubt and insecurity postbreakup, even being on the whole quite positive in self-esteem (Chung et al. 2002) or nonsignificant (O'Sullivan et al. 2019). For instance, 71% believed others performed tasks better than they did, and 60% reported nervousness around strangers, feelings of inferiority and self-directed anger. Additionally, 50% feared appearing unintelligent, hesitated to express their ideas and placed greater trust in others' competence than in their own. Concerns about physical appearance were also notable, with 57% perceiving themselves as ugly, 40% feeling inferior to others, 30% feeling not very likeable and 37% experiencing shame. Moreover, 29% did not like themselves and wished they were someone else (Chung et al. 2002). Elevated levels of breakup distress were also associated with less self-compassion and self-forgiveness (Akbari et al. 2022). An analysis from 2018, by Fang and colleagues, reveals that participants showed more negative cognitions about the self, followed by emotional reliance on others and avoidance. In this study, social dysfunction was higher than anxiety, somatization and depression.

Individuals who wrote about losses and gains emphasized internal and interpersonal aspects related to their breakup, focusing more on gains like freedom, space, trust and time for self-improvement. They commonly expressed a desire to 'work on myself' and 'figure out my issues' (Primeau et al. 2013). Identity clarity emerged as a crucial factor in postbreakup resilience and decision-making. Recommendations from participants underscored the importance of therapeutic interventions to clarify relationship goals, enhance interpersonal competence and facilitate identity exploration for informed decision-making

in fostering healthy intimacy development (Washburn-Busk et al. 2020).

3.3.3 | Hypothesis 3. The psychological impact of a breakup will decrease over time, whereas psychosocial developmental outcomes will increase or remain more stable

Empirical support for this hypothesis was limited. Most of the included studies did not show longitudinal evidence, and studies focusing on psychosocial development found mixed results, depending on the specific measure analysed. Unfortunately, many studies did not use validated measures, raising concerns about the reliability of their findings. The evaluation of psychosocial developmental outcomes was even more inconsistent, with some studies relying on single-item measures or creating scales specifically for the study. This lack of standardized assessment tools limits the ability to draw definitive conclusions about the trajectory of psychological distress and psychosocial developmental changes following a breakup.

3.3.3.1 | Psychological Health. In the short term, participants reported significant distress, including sadness, anger and lingering feelings of love with resistance to accepting relationship termination, with notable differences in the first week compared to those in ongoing relationships. However, by the end of 28 days, these emotions had stabilized to levels comparable to individuals who were still dating. Notably, the dissolution group showed greater variability in their emotional responses across all time points. Sadness tended to decrease at a slower rate for individuals with initially high levels of distress, accounting for 31% of within variation. Anger, on the other hand, showed a sharp decline within the first 5 days, although for some participants, further reductions continued to be significant beyond this period (32%). Relief followed a similar pattern, with those experiencing greater relief at the outset demonstrating a slower decline in this feeling over time (33%; Sbarra and Emery 2005). In a longer longitudinal study, Barber and Cooper (2014) showed a significant decline in anger and distress over time, reaching distress's lowest level approximately 5–6 months after the breakup. However, distress and anger levels in partner-initiated relationships were higher at 4 weeks but declined more quickly, eventually converging with those of self-initiators around 22 weeks. It is relevant to note that these studies do not use validated scales and only examine emotions over time. A recent study by Gehl et al. (2024) found that higher levels of anxiety and depression experienced immediately after a breakup were associated with higher levels of these symptoms over time. However, a gradual decrease was observed at 1- and 3-month follow-ups. On the other hand, Wang et al. (2024) found an increase in depression after the breakup during the COVID-19 pandemic, highlighting the importance of contextual and social environments in adjustment to this experience. Evidence from Shulman and Yonatan-Leus (2024) suggests that, although initial levels of breakup distress were associated with lower depression, an increase in breakup distress over 8 years predicted future levels of depressive and anxiety symptoms. Their findings also indicate that personal growth minimally explained future psychological outcomes but served as a protective factor against the negative effect of breakup distress over time. In 2016, Palacio-González and colleagues

found that distress immediately following a breakup accounted for 69% of breakup distress after 7 months, whereas posttraumatic growth explained only 28%.

3.3.3.2 | Psychosocial Development. Concerning psychosocial development, conclusions emphasized the significant role of participants' perceptions of postbreakup growth. Although actual personal growth did not increase significantly from the beginning (T1) to the end of the semester (T2), and no differences were found between individuals who experienced a breakup and those who did not at T2, participants still perceived significant growth at T2. As previously noted, experiencing a breakup per se was not significantly associated with actual growth over time, but the impact of the event influenced both actual and perceived growth (Owenz and Fowers 2019). Once again, this result highlights the importance of how the breakup was processed. For example, higher intrusive thoughts at an earlier stage and more deliberate reflections 7 months later reported greater long-term posttraumatic growth (Palacio-González et al. 2016). Conversely, those with lower intrusive thoughts required a greater degree of deliberate thinking to achieve similar levels of growth. Results regarding identity and intimacy dimensions present a more complex picture. According to Barber and Cooper (2014), self-esteem trajectories varied based on distress periods. Individuals experiencing a shorter distress period reported earlier increases, whereas those with prolonged distress showed a slight initial decline before improving. Relationship duration also influenced self-esteem trajectories, with longer relationships associated with a slight decline and shorter relationships associated with an increase. No significant differences in self-esteem were found between initiators and noninitiators at 4 weeks. Although social self-esteem increased over time, appearance self-esteem remained unchanged. For the intimacy dimension, Shulman and Yonatan-Leus (2024) showed that earlier anxiety led to greater attachment to a future partner, but lower overall romantic competence after 8 years. In contrast, initial levels of breakup distress were associated with greater coherence and meaning in future relationships. Although an increase in breakup distress over 8 years contributed to more preoccupied attachment in future relationships, it simultaneously fostered a greater sense of meaning in relationships.

3.3.4 | Hypothesis 4. Socio-demographic factors will be associated with both psychological health and psychosocial developmental outcomes

Table 4 presents a summary of the results of the factors analysed in the included studies in both psychological health (PH) and psychosocial development (PD) outcomes following romantic breakups. It indicates whether results were positive (+), negative (–) or nonsignificant (0), along with the number of occurrences (shown as an exponent, e.g., ‘–2’ indicates two negative associations). The shaded row of the table provides the total number of positive, null and negative results across all studies for both PH and PD outcomes.

Regarding socio-demographic factors, most studies did not find significant results. However, some studies suggest that women experience a greater negative psychological impact but a more

Socio factors														
Age	1	10	1	0	1	0	0 ³ −							
Sex (female)	1	33	11	6	14	5	0 − 0 ³ 0	0 − 0 −	0 ⁶ 0	0 ⁹ −	0	0	0 ²	0 ³ +
Income levels	0	6	1	0	2	0		0 ² −		0 ⁶				
Year in college	0	1	0	0	0	0			0					
Race	0	1	0	0	0	0								0
Academic stress	0	1	0	0	0	0								0
Contextual relationship factors														
Initiator status	17	15	1	2	9	0	0 0 + ² 0 ² +	0 ² + + ²		0 ⁷ −	0	0 ²	0 + 0 + ⁷ +	0 ³ +
Time since breakup	9	17	1	1	9	0	0 ² + +	0 ² +	+ ²	+	0 + 0 ⁴ 0 + ³	0	0 ² 0 0	0 ⁴
Relationship duration	0	9	5	2	1	0	+ ² − 0		− ²			0 − 0 −	0 ²	0 ⁴
Current dating	12	8	2	3	9	0	+ ³ +	0 ³ + ³ 0 ³			0 +	0 ² + 0 0 ²	0 0 + + ² 0 ²	0 +
Commitment	0	8	1	0	5	0	0 ² − 0					0 ²		0 ⁴
Suddenness	0	2	2	0	0	0	0 ² − −							
Closeness	0	1	2	1	1	1	0 −			0 +			−	
Seriousness	0	2	0	0	0	0				−				
Relationship satisfaction	0	0	0	0	5	0	0 ³				0 ²			0 ²

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										(Continues)									

[illegible]

positive impact on psychosocial development. To better understand how psychosocial development varied across sex, we were only able to conduct a meta-analysis based on three studies using PTGI that reported complete statistical data required for the procedure (see Data S3). The results reassured that women on average experience higher levels of posttraumatic growth compared to men. This difference is statistically significant, with a moderate effect size of 0.56. In the case of age and income levels, they appeared not to be significant factors for both psychological health and psychosocial development (11 in 13 results and 8 in 9 results, respectively).

3.3.5 | Hypothesis 5. Contextual factors will be associated with both psychological health and psychosocial developmental outcomes

The results from the studies support this hypothesis, showing that contextual factors are significantly associated with psychological and developmental outcomes after a breakup, although studies have found mixed findings (see Table 4).

In terms of relationship contextual factors, findings suggest that initiators of the breakup experience less psychological distress, indicating that partner-initiated breakups were associated with more distress (Barber and Cooper 2014; Boelen and Reijntjes 2008; Chung and Hunt 2014; Park et al. 2011; Perilloux and Buss 2008; Randelović and Goljović 2020; Wrape et al. 2016). However, it is important to note that most study participants were initiators (46%), which can influence these results. For psychosocial development, the initiator did not seem to be significant (nine in 11 results). Similarly, a longer time since breakup was associated with less distress, although it is important to refer to the fact that most studies did not find significance (17 in 27 results) and examined only short timeframes (a few weeks to 1 year after breakup). An additional point to consider is that it may depend on the outcome. For example, time since breakup seemed more associated with avoidance rather than the intrusion of the event (Chung and Hunt 2014). Identifying benefit from the breakup (three in four results) and being currently in a new relationship were also associated with lower distress (12 in 22 results). Current dating was associated with less preoccupation and rumination, better general adjustment (Saffrey and Ehrenberg 2007), fewer general symptoms (Tashiro and Frazier 2003), complicated grief (Boelen and Reijntjes 2008) and depression (Boelen and Reijntjes 2008; Samios et al. 2014), increased positive affect (Samios et al. 2014) and smaller declines in satisfaction of life over time (Rhoades et al. 2011). On the other hand, individuals currently dating do not seem to show significant differences in posttraumatic growth and other psychosocial developmental outcomes compared to single individuals (9 in 12 results). The results also indicate that being in a rebound relationship had positive effects on both psychological health and psychosocial development (6 in 7 results). Although more results did not show significant results, some studies showed that longer relationships were linked to more psychological distress (5 negative and 9 null), but greater developmental benefits (2 positive; 1 null). The best quality studies just analysed psychological health and showed five no significant results and three

negative, reassuring the lack of significance of results of relationship duration on psychological health (Hawley et al. 2015; Palacio-González et al. 2017; Park et al. 2011; Samios et al. 2014). Most studies indicated no significant differences regarding the number of breakups (2 in 3 results), contact with an ex (4 in 5 results), feelings for an ex-partner (10 in 13 results) or commitment levels (13 in 14 results). However, the closeness in the relationship seemed to have a negative association with psychological health (2 in 3 results). The level of satisfaction in previous relationships did not appear to be related to developmental adjustment after breakup (5 null results). However, understanding the reasons for the breakup was found to be important for personal development (3 in 5 results), emphasizing the importance of cognitive processes in postbreakup developmental adjustment, mostly for conflict and relationship satisfaction in future relationships, and intimate competence over time perceived by the peers (Kansky and Allen 2018). Additionally, individuals who reported more frequent positive and negative memories exhibited higher levels of depressive symptoms and breakup distress, but this was analysed by a single study only. When compared with academic content, a distinction finding emerged with the frequency of relationship-related memories associated with more depressive symptoms and breakup distress (Palacio-González et al. 2017).

Regarding social contextual factors, social connectedness emerged as an important protective factor for both psychological impact and personal development (4 positive results); although only one study examined this aspect in four different outcomes (loneliness, hopelessness, stress and symptomatology; Moller et al. 2003).

When considering only factors with multiple outcomes and a predominance of positive or negative significance (without more nonsignificant results), the most relevant contextual factors for psychological health include initiator status, current dating, rebound, benefit finding, closeness, social connectedness and sacred loss/desecration as protective factors. In contrast, relationship-related factors with both positive and negative memories emerged as risk factors. For psychosocial development, protective factors include understanding the reasons, relationship duration and rebound, whereas no risk factors were found.

3.3.6 | Hypothesis 6. Individual factors will be associated with both psychological health and psychosocial developmental outcomes

In terms of individual factors, this hypothesis was also supported, although the results revealed some complexities, highlighting the nuanced role of individual differences in post-breakup adjustment.

Within attachment styles, secure attachment was the most protective factor for psychological health (7 in 8 results), whereas attachment anxiety was associated with greater psychological distress (18 in 30 results). Specifically, attachment anxiety demonstrates direct and indirect effects and maintains significance even after controlling for gender and other relevant variables (Boelen and Reijntjes 2008; Heshmati et al. 2022; Marshall

et al. 2013; Randelović and Goljović 2020). In general, high attachment anxiety was associated with hopes of reuniting, higher relationship expectations and less closure after the breakup (Saffrey and Ehrenberg 2007). Although most studies indicate nonsignificant results (5 results, 3 positive and 2 negative), individuals with high attachment anxiety seemed also more likely to anticipate and recall changes in self-concept (15%–21%) but also confusion (16%–22%) after the end of a relationship (Slotter and Gardner 2012). For example, preoccupied attachment influenced self-worth reliance on romantic relationships (Park et al. 2011). But it was attachment avoidance that seemed more significant, revealing a negative impact on personal development (3 in 4 results), though it may initially reduce psychological distress (2 positive, 13 null and 2 negative). In sum, attachment secure, anxiety and avoidance were related to personal growth postbreakup, with secure and anxious individuals more likely and avoidant individuals less likely to transform breakup distress into personal growth.

Regarding personality traits, findings on neuroticism were mixed (7 to 5 results), but when differences were observed, they generally indicated a negative effect on psychological well-being. When combined with other personality traits, neuroticism emerged as the exclusive personality trait associated with psychological health, comprising 23%. When combined with dating-related factors, it explained 38% of distress (Tashiro and Frazier 2003). Among other personality traits, only agreeableness was associated with higher personal growth, contributing to 12% of the variance, though this finding was based on a single study.

The impact of past experiences significantly shapes how individuals experience romantic breakups (7 negative results in a total of 8). These findings underscore the intricate relationship between past experiences and mental health outcomes, with PTSD from past trauma increasing 29% of posttraumatic stress symptoms (PTSS), 19% of psychological comorbidity (Studley and Chung 2015) and 19% of general health (Chung and Hunt 2014). Childhood maltreatment also increased negative psychological symptoms postbreakup (5 negative results).

Self-esteem emerged as an important protective factor against psychological distress (5 in 8 results). For example, negative self-esteem explained 20.1% of general health, according to Chung et al.'s (2002) study. Although just a single study analysed and showed negative results for psychosocial development, a qualitative study by Washburn-Busk et al. (2020) revealed that factors such as a clear sense of self, alignment with personal values, confidence and noncontingent self-esteem promote a healthier approach to romantic connections. A participant in the study highlighted how past breakups influenced her ability to be independent and confident, which, in turn, improved her dedication to future relationships. Factors such as undefined values, low confidence and reliance on relationship-contingent self-esteem were identified as obstacles to the formation and sustenance of healthy connections.

Other factors linked to psychological health included emotional dependency and grit. In the prediction of negative psychological health, emotional dependency emerged as an important risk element, whereas grit emerged as a protective

factor. In our findings, the concept of relationship contingency of self-worth stood out as a significant predictor (Park et al. 2011). For some individuals, their self-concept is closely tied to the status of their romantic relationships and, when these relationships end, it significantly impacts how they feel about themselves, increasing psychological distress. For personal development, no studies analysed the impact of these factors, but Washburn-Busk et al. (2020) in their qualitative study showed that codependency, characterized by seeking validation and deriving self-worth from the relationship, impedes their ability to navigate and define their relationships. In this study, identity clarity also emerged as a crucial factor in postbreakup resilience and decision-making. Individuals with an unstable or underdeveloped identity, characterized by undefined values, low confidence, jealousy and codependency, showed greater difficulty in adapting to the breakup. In contrast, those with a well-defined identity outside the relationship demonstrated stronger decision-making resilience, particularly in recognizing life goal differences, setting boundaries and making deliberate breakup decisions. On the other hand, Lewandoski et al.'s studies (Lewandowski et al. 2006; Lewandowski and Bizzoco 2007) showed that self-expansion was associated with less personal development. In the first study (2006), the authors showed that ending a relationship with a partner perceived as offering low self-expansion was associated with a more diverse self-concept, whereas ending with a high self-expansion partner was associated with a less diverse self-concept and greater loss of identity. The second study (2007) showed that predissolution self-expansion was negatively related to growth and rediscovery of self but positively related to loss of self.

The most relevant individual factors for psychological health include secure attachment, self-esteem and grit as protective factors. Risk factors include anxiety attachment, past trauma experiences, childhood maltreatment and emotional dependency. For psychosocial development, risk factors include avoidance attachment and self-expansion, whereas no protective factors were found.

3.3.7 | Hypothesis 7. Psychological mechanisms will be associated with both psychological health and psychosocial developmental outcomes

Regarding mechanisms, negative cognitions and rumination were associated with higher psychological distress (5 in 8 results and 6 in 7 results, respectively), although deliberate and reflective rumination was linked to more positive outcomes in psychosocial development (3 in 5 results). For example, catastrophic misinterpretations jointly with self-blame explain a substantial 27% of depression and 25% of anxiety (Boelen and Reijntjes 2008). Experiencing both positive and negative emotions was also associated with less psychological health (2 total negative) and greater personal development (2 total positive).

Among coping strategies, problem-focused coping appeared to have more positive effects on psychological and developmental outcomes, although there was a larger number of nonsignificant results (16 null; 4 positive), whereas avoidant coping was

consistently associated with negative effects (11 in 17 results). In fact, coping strategies played a crucial role, explaining 36% of the impact (Chung et al. 2003) and 28%–33% of distress (Randelović and Goljović 2020). Self-blame as an emotion-focused coping strategy was a risk-detrimental factor analysed in the included studies for psychological health (8 in 9 results). On the other hand, emotional regulation showed positive effects on psychological health (5 results) but with mixed results (18 null and 2 negative). Just a single study analysed the role of emotional regulation on psychosocial development, showing a positive effect (Francoeur et al. 2020). It is important to note that emotional regulation was analysed with different measures and constructs concerning different components of emotional regulation in different outcomes, which can be the reason for such nuanced results. For example, Chung and Hunt (2014), a study of good quality, showed that suppressed anxiety was negatively related to avoidance behaviour, difficulty in identifying feelings with more negative general health and difficulty describing feelings with less intrusive thoughts. No significant results were found for suppressing anger and depression. These results highlight the complexity of emotions and emotional intelligence on breakup adjustment.

In terms of types of loss, no significance was observed between relationship loss, but when self-loss was emphasized, outcomes were more negative for both psychological and developmental factors. Lastly, the attribution of the cause of breakup, control and stability of the cause did not seem significant for both psychological health and psychosocial development.

The most relevant mechanisms and processes factors for psychological health include negative cognitions, positive and negative emotions, intrusive rumination, COPE avoidance, self-blame and self-loss as risk factors. No protective factors were found. For psychosocial development, the single risk factor was self-loss, whereas protective factors include deliberative and reflective rumination and experiencing both positive and negative emotions.

3.3.8 | Hypothesis 8. Individual and mechanism factors will have a more significant impact over time than contextual factors

Only eight studies have explicitly examined the influence of these factors over time, and the available evidence presents a complex picture, with some findings supporting the hypothesis, whereas others suggest no significant differences. This highlights a gap in the literature and underscores the need for future research to explore how individual and contextual factors interact and evolve in shaping psychological and psychosocial developmental outcomes over time.

Gender, family income and parental marital status were not significant predictors of long-term psychological or developmental outcomes, including depression, anxiety, internalizing symptoms, intimate competence, autonomy and conflict in future relationships (Kansky and Allen 2018; Gehl et al. 2024; Shulman and Yonatan-Leus 2024; Wang et al. 2024). Contrarily, Owenz and Fowers (2019) showed that female participants revealed more personal growth after months of the first response. This

can be explained by the outcome used in the included studies showing the nuanced results for gender.

Across the studies, contextual factors such as initiator status, relationship duration, contact with ex, time since breakup, understanding the reasons, current dating, relationship satisfaction, commitment, living together, plans for marriage, sharing a child, desire for dissolution and relationship quality were assessed for their long-term effects. Most of these factors showed no significant long-term effects. Initiator status presents mixed results, depending on the outcome used. It was not significant for anxiety or anger trajectories in one study but was related to smaller decreases in internalizing symptoms from ages 22 to 25 (Kansky and Allen 2018) and quick recovery from distress over time in another (Barber and Cooper 2014). Barber and Cooper (2014) also showed that noninitiators, although starting with low social self-esteem, recovered more quickly, converging with initiators by 22 weeks postbreakup. In the other studies, initiating a breakup did not significantly predict any changes in self-reported satisfaction over time, peer-reported intimate competence (Kansky and Allen 2018) and perceived growth (Owenz and Fowers 2019). However, emerging adults who initiated a breakup were subsequently involved in romantic relationships where both partners engaged in behaviours that undermined autonomous functioning (Kansky and Allen 2018). Longer relationship durations were associated with higher social self-esteem. In contrast, appearance self-esteem showed a slight decline in longer relationships but significantly increased for those in shorter relationships (Barber and Cooper 2014). Living together and plans for marriage were associated with greater declines in life satisfaction, whereas higher relationship quality and current dating predicted smaller declines but no psychological distress (Rhoades et al. 2011). Current dating, on the other hand, was not associated with perceived or actual growth (Owenz and Fowers 2019). Although understanding the reasons did not present significant results for psychological health, greater understanding related to less conflict in later relationships, an increase in relationship satisfaction and intimate competence perceived by friends over time (Kansky and Allen 2018). These findings suggest that while some contextual factors can influence initial distress or long-term adjustment, they generally do not have a strong or consistent impact on long-term outcomes.

Individual factors such as neuroticism, attachment, past trauma and optimism showed more consistent effects on long-term outcomes, although there was limited evidence. Optimism was not a significant predictor of either perceived or actual growth, whereas past trauma was associated with higher perceived growth but showed no effect on actual growth (Owenz and Fowers 2019). This distinction highlights the importance of differentiating between perceived and actual growth, as individuals may subjectively feel they have grown from the experience, even when objective measures do not reflect significant change. Concerning attachment, anxiety and avoidance were not significantly associated with anxiety or depression at 1 and 3 months postbreakup (Gehl et al. 2024). On the other hand, Sbarra and Emery (2005) showed that dismissive attachment appeared to be associated with a slower decline in anger over time, whereas both fearful and secure attachment showed a slower decline in sadness. No significant effects were found for preoccupied

attachment (Sbarra and Emery 2005) and neuroticism (Wang et al. 2024).

Psychological mechanisms also play a crucial role in long-term postbreakup adjustment. Self-punishment coping was associated with higher levels of anxiety and depression, whereas accommodation was related to lower depression (Shulman and Yonatan-Leus 2024). In contrast, emotional intrusion, self-blame (Sbarra and Emery 2005), as well as approach, self-help and avoidance strategies showed no significant effects over time (Shulman and Yonatan-Leus 2024). The type of rumination also played a crucial role, with deliberate rumination positively associated with long-term growth and breakup distress, and intrusive rumination having no significant effect on distress or growth or associated with more breakup distress (in the case of brooding). In fact, cognitive processes can play a combined role in influencing individuals' postdissolution growth. For example, higher initial intrusive thoughts (T1) coupled with increased deliberate thoughts 7 months later (T2) contribute to greater postdissolution growth. This interaction explains 24% of the variance at T1 and 49.5% at T2. Individuals with lower initial intrusive thoughts need relatively higher deliberate thinking to achieve comparable postdissolution growth compared to those with greater initial intrusive thoughts (Palacio-González et al. 2016).

In sum, the findings indicate that long-term factors include relationship duration, understanding the reasons, past trauma, attachment, self-punishment and accommodation coping and type of rumination. Given the limited number of studies examining long-term effects, it is essential to interpret these results with caution, because further research is needed to confirm these findings and explore the interaction between other contextual and individual factors in postbreakup adjustment over time.

3.3.9 | Hypothesis 9. Coping mechanisms will mediate the relationship between breakup and psychosocial effects

The findings provide mixed evidence regarding the mediating role of coping mechanisms in the relationship between breakup and psychosocial outcomes. Some coping strategies were significant mediators, whereas others showed no effect. Self-compassion and self-forgiveness did not significantly mediate the relationship between breakup distress and depression. However, self-forgiveness became a significant mediator when included as part of a broader mediation model (Akbari et al. 2022). Similarly, self-silencing did not mediate the association between relationship or self-loss and outcomes such as depression and dependency (Drew et al. 2004).

Cognitive factors played a crucial role, with negative cognitions about the self and self-blame fully mediating the association between PTSS and general psychological health (GHQ). Assertion of autonomy further moderated this mediational effect, suggesting that autonomy may buffer the impact of negative cognitions on distress outcomes (Fang et al. 2018). Specific cognitive mechanisms such as brooding, reflection and dwelling (brooding

with regret) were significant mediators between attachment anxiety and growth, suggesting that individuals with higher attachment anxiety are more likely to engage in rumination, which may later contribute to personal development (Marshall et al. 2013; Saffrey and Ehrenberg 2007). Specifically, brooding and reflection mediated the relationship between breakup distress and growth, as well as between attachment avoidance and growth. Notably, avoidance was only significant through its effect on distress, meaning that although it initially led to lower distress, its indirect association with rumination ultimately contributed to greater growth (Marshall et al. 2013). Dwelling played a crucial role as well, mediating the relationship between attachment anxiety and general positive adjustment in a positive direction while also fully mediating the relationship between attachment anxiety and general negative adjustment. Reflection, in another study, was not a significant mediator of general adjustment (Saffrey and Ehrenberg 2007).

Coping strategies also had differential effects in the context of past trauma. Problem-focused coping negatively mediated the relationship between past trauma and the impact of the breakup, whereas emotion-focused coping positively mediated this relationship, as well as the relationships between past trauma and psychological health. Interestingly, personal growth did not mediate these effects, indicating that while some coping strategies influence how past trauma relates to breakup mental health outcomes, perceived growth does not play a mediating role in this context (Studley and Chung 2015). On the other hand, personal growth served as a protective factor against the negative effect of breakup distress on anxiety over eight years of study (Shulman and Yonatan-Leus 2024). Among coping strategies, self-punishment and accommodation coping were the only significant mediators over time. Specifically, individuals with higher anxious attachment were more likely to use self-punishment coping, which, in turn, was associated with greater anxiety and depressive symptoms at 1 and 3 months postbreakup. Anxiously attached individuals were also less likely to use accommodation coping, which was linked to higher depressive symptoms over time. Similarly, individuals with higher avoidant attachment showed greater use of self-punishment coping, which increased anxiety symptoms at one and 3 months, but not depression at 3 months. Avoidantly attached individuals were less likely to use accommodation coping, which was also associated with higher depressive symptoms over time (Gehl et al. 2024). In addition, breakup distress itself acted as a mediator between attachment and growth. Higher attachment avoidance was associated with lower distress and, in turn, lower growth, whereas higher attachment anxiety was associated with greater distress and subsequently more growth. However, this effect was indirect, as attachment anxiety did not have a direct effect on growth (Marshall et al. 2013). However, self-concept change mediated the relationship between attachment anxiety and self-concept confusion, reinforcing the idea that attachment styles shape how individuals reconstruct their sense of self after a breakup (Slotter and Gardner 2012).

Emotional regulation also emerged as a key mediator, particularly in the context of childhood maltreatment. It mediated the relationship between childhood maltreatment and resilience (9.2%), psychological distress (20.3%) and psychological symptoms (BSI, 12.9%), with lower emotional regulation linked to worse outcomes. Mentalization was significant only for BSI (5%),

but self-related mentalization was a significant mediator across all outcomes (4.8%, 9.5%, 2.6%) and was generally associated with poorer results. In Francoeur et al.'s (2020) study, participants with more childhood maltreatment histories evoked more difficulties in emotional regulation and self-related mentalization, which leads to more breakup distress. Childhood maltreatment was inversely related to resilience, even when these measures were included as mediators. Emotion suppression also significantly mediated the effects of childhood maltreatment, attachment anxiety and closeness on breakup grief, but was not significant in the relationship between attachment dependency and breakup grief (Heshmati et al. 2022).

Finally, predissolution self-expansion positively influences post-breakup growth through the mediating factors of rediscovering the self and experiencing loss of self. Additionally, various psychological processes, including positive reinterpretation, acceptance, social support, denial, mental disengagement and venting, were not identified as mediators in the impact of predissolution self-expansion on subsequent growth (Lewandowski and Bizzoco 2007).

In conclusion, several coping mechanisms were found to be significant mediators of psychological health after a breakup, particularly negative cognitions about self and self-blame, emotional regulation, mentalization and self-related mentalization, brooding and dwelling rumination, problem-focused coping and emotion-focused coping. Emotional regulation, self-related mentalization, brooding and reflection rumination, breakup distress, self-concept change, self-loss and rediscovery of self also played an important mediating role between individual and contextual factors associated with breakup and psychosocial development, facilitating personal growth and resilience after a breakup. Autonomy was also important to decrease the effects of negative personal mechanisms on breakup adjustment.

4 | Discussion

The main aim of this systematic review was to identify and describe the psychosocial effects experienced by emerging adults following a romantic breakup, focusing on identifying specific variables associated with identity and intimacy development, as well as psychosocial well-being. This is the first review of romantic breakups and psychosocial adjustment in the field of interpersonal relationships during emerging adulthood.

The findings indicate that the majority of the studies yielded mixed results and have primarily focused on predictors rather than processes and consequences following the breakup. This aligns with a recent review that examined how breakups have been studied over the past 20 years (Machia et al. 2023). From the compiled results of this systematic review, empirical evidence varied across the included studies in support of each of the nine hypotheses. In most cases, evidence showed significant effects of romantic breakups on psychosocial outcomes, both psychological health and psychosocial development (Hypotheses 1 and 2). The hypothesis testing the psychosocial trajectories of romantic breakups over time (Hypotheses 3 and 8) remains largely untested, with few studies specifically examining these objectives. For the hypothesis about the influence of factors on

psychosocial experiences after a breakup (Hypotheses 4,5,6,7 and 8), mixed effects were found. Lastly, the hypothesis on the mediation role of coping mechanisms (Hypothesis 9) was supported by 10 studies. The comprehensive analysis of these studies provides valuable insights into the diverse factors that can influence individuals' experiences during this challenging period.

4.1 | Psychosocial Effects of Romantic Breakups and Long-Term Trajectories

Despite the majority of findings demonstrating evidence suggesting the significant effect of romantic breakups on psychological health (Hypothesis 1), it is important to consider that Drew et al. (2004) introduce an important perspective, indicating that the emotional impact of a breakup on depressive symptoms was not directly influenced by the end of the relationship but instead by the impact of self-loss. This result suggests that breakups should be examined as a multidimensional experience rather than a singular life event (Kellas and Masunov 2003). According to Self Psychology (Kohut 1977), a relationship dissolution can reactivate pre-existing vulnerabilities and patterns of self-organization, potentially leading to fragmentation and difficulties in restoring a stable self-structure. This process resembles Bowen's (1978) notions about differentiation of self, as individuals with lower differentiation tend to experience greater distress and self-loss. These perspectives suggest that future research should explore deeper patterns of self-structuring following a breakup that can contribute to the recovery process, which may involve a broader examination of personal history and internalized models of self and relational dynamics.

Studies showing evidence in support of Hypothesis 2 found that romantic breakups contributed to personal growth (e.g., Tashiro and Frazier 2003), identity consolidation (e.g., Lewandowski et al. 2006; Lewandowski and Bizzoco 2007) and intimacy competence (e.g., Perilloux and Buss 2008). This is a notable advancement in the field as it reframes this phenomenon not as a simply distressing event, but as a potential facilitator for developmental change. This perspective aligns with lifespan developmental theories, which emphasize the role of transitional life experiences, particularly emerging adulthood, in establishing life structure and shaping intimacy development (e.g., Arnett 2000; Erikson 1968; Levinson 1986). It also brings into line attachment theory, which reinforces the enduring importance of attachment needs throughout the lifespan (Ainsworth and Bowlby 1991). Therefore, this review highlights how relationship dissolution may provide opportunities to redefine their self-concept, reassess relational needs and refine their attachment styles. Nevertheless, actual growth appears to be associated with the impact of the event rather than the experience of the breakup itself (Owenz and Fowers 2019). Once again, the period of revaluation and reorganization aftermath of the breakup may have a greater influence on personal growth than the occurrence of the event per se, suggesting the need for interventions that support this period and foster deeper self-reflection and meaning-making.

Although studies supported a decline in psychological impact, longitudinal evidence remains limited, making it difficult to

establish clear recovery trajectories (Hypothesis 3). However, the results provide an initial and crucial overview of psychosocial trajectories following breakups, by suggesting that developmental processes can continue to progress. Interventions may benefit from extending beyond the immediate emotional support to also foster long-term developmental change (e.g., fostering secure attachment, promoting differentiation of self). Recognizing breakups as a developmental process rather than a distressing event may encourage a shift in therapeutic approaches, moving from symptom reduction toward enhancing adaptive intra- and interpersonal capacities. A relevant example comes from the recommendations of participants in Washburn-Busk et al. (2020)' study, who underscored the importance of therapeutic interventions to clarify relationship goals, enhance interpersonal competence and facilitate identity exploration for informed decision-making in fostering healthy intimacy development.

4.2 | Contextual and Individual Factors in Breakup Adjustment

Findings related to socio-demographic factors (Hypothesis 4) suggested that they are more nuanced than previously assumed. Concerning sex, women experience a greater negative psychological impact but a more positive impact on psychosocial development. Men, on average, are more likely to suppress their emotions, which could indicate fewer opportunities for self-reflection and growth following the breakup (Flynn et al. 2010). This highlights the need for interventions that encourage balanced emotional processing and self-exploration to facilitate long-term relational and personal growth.

Some contextual factors also play a significant role in both psychological health and psychosocial development (Hypothesis 5). Initiators exhibit higher levels of adjustment due to having more time to process the breakup (Boelen and Reijntjes 2008), but they also struggle to forgive themselves, which may explain the elevated nonsignificant results (Akbari et al. 2022). Although current dating and rebound relationships may facilitate adjustment by providing emotional support and distraction (Barber and Cooper 2014), both positive and negative memories emerged as risk factors, reinforcing the need for strategies that help integrate these memories constructively and facilitate a sense of closure. Importantly, social connectedness and sacred loss/desecration also serve as protective factors. Future research should explore how cultural and social norms can shape the breakup experience, as most studies focus on Western, individualistic contexts. Understanding the reasons for the breakup and longer relationships can have a protective effect on personal growth, possibly due to their greater experience and deeper understanding and learning of relational dynamics (e.g., Barber and Cooper 2014; Kansky and Allen 2018; Palacio-González et al. 2017). Furthermore, benefit finding and closeness in past relationships may help individuals reframe the breakup as an opportunity for growth.

Individual differences such as attachment style, self-esteem, emotional dependency and past trauma played a critical role in shaping postbreakup trajectories (Hypothesis 6). Secure

attachment, self-esteem and grit may facilitate better psychological health, whereas anxious attachment, emotional dependency and past trauma may heighten distress (e.g., Boelen and Reijntjes 2008; Chung and Hunt 2014). The enduring impact of past trauma and childhood maltreatment can significantly impact romantic relationships, contributing to barriers to intimacy, trust issues and difficulties in expressing emotions (e.g., McCarthy and Maughan 2010). Healing unresolved emotional wounds is essential for fostering healthy relationships, as it enables individuals to develop resilience and self-awareness (Ardelt and Grunwald 2018). On the other hand, avoidant attachment and high self-expansion, often associated with fusion with a partner, may inhibit personal growth after a breakup by limiting deeper reflection and knowledge on relational experiences (Marshall et al. 2013) and complicating the process of redefining the sense of self (Lewandowski et al. 2006). Early emotional interactions play a crucial role in adult relationships, with attachment patterns influencing partner selection, providing the foundation for trust, self-concept, resilience, effective communication and coping mechanisms during stress. These findings emphasize the need for interventions that address underlying attachment insecurities and self-worth contingencies rather than focusing solely on breakup distress (McCarthy and Maughan 2010).

4.3 | Psychological Mechanisms in Breakup Adjustment

The study explored numerous psychological mechanisms shaping individuals' psychological health and psychosocial development (Hypothesis 7). Negative cognitions, emotional processing, intrusive rumination, COPE avoidance and self-blame were found to reinforce distress by fostering unresolved feelings or reinforcing feelings of guilt or inadequacy (e.g., Boelen and Reijntjes 2008; Saffrey and Ehrenberg 2007). The experience of a breakup can also provide an opportunity for self-reflection that contributes to healing and developing a more secure sense of self for future relationships (Ruvolo et al. 2001). Additionally, although emotions wield a significant negative influence on individuals' well-being, they contribute positively to psychosocial development (e.g., Hawley et al. 2015; Primeau et al. 2013). Understanding and managing these emotions is essential for cultivating emotional resilience, promoting self-awareness and navigating the challenges of moving forward (Meier et al. 2024).

When the factors are examined over time (Hypothesis 8), only some of these emerged as significant for long-term adjustment, including relationship duration, understanding the reasons, past trauma, insecure attachment style, self-punishment and accommodation coping, as well as the type of rumination. These results support the Model of Developmental Adaptation (Martin and Martin 2002), which emphasizes how development emerges from the interaction between immediate emotional distress and distal influences such as early relational experiences, internalized self-structures and coping mechanisms. However, empirical research on this hypothesis is still limited and inconsistent. Further refinement is needed to enhance the predictive accuracy of both individual and contextual factors and their interaction over time.

The evidence identified in support of Hypothesis 9 further highlights the importance of developmental perspectives by suggesting the role of psychological processes in the aftermath of the breakup. Although they did not have a direct effect on psychosocial outcomes, emotional regulation and mentalization contributed to better adjustment and personal growth (e.g., Francoeur et al. 2020; Spielmann et al. 2009). Effective emotional regulation enhances satisfaction and conflict resolution, whereas mentalization cultivates understanding between partners (e.g., DiMaggio 2020). These skills contribute to the development of secure attachments, crucial for navigating the challenges of emerging adulthood as individuals undergo identity exploration, intimacy development and life transitions (Ainsworth and Bowlby 1991; Arnett 2000). Breakup distress, self-concept change, self-loss and rediscovery of self also played an important mediating role between breakup circumstances and psychosocial development, facilitating personal growth and resilience after a breakup. On the other hand, autonomy and problem-focused coping were important to decrease the effects of negative individuals' experiences on breakup adjustment, whereas intrusive rumination and emotion-focused coping mechanisms such as self-blame and negative cognitions about self can amplify the negative effects (e.g., Studley and Chung 2015). These findings reinforce the earlier discussion, emphasizing the importance of integrating psychological processes and restructuring internalized patterns for effective breakup adjustment in life and self-structure.

5 | Strengths and Limitations

It is important to note that the outcomes of the included studies had been measured in diverse ways, which may contribute to the lack of clarity and the difficulty of compiling all the results. Researchers employed 65 different instruments for analysing psychological health and psychosocial development. The lack of validated and specialized tools specifically designed for the context of romantic breakups is an important issue in this area of research. For instance, the BDS is the most commonly used and referenced instrument in the literature and was adapted from the Inventory of Complicated Grief (ICG), a scale developed for grief in the context of death. As such, the BDS may overlook important psychosocial aspects when considering breakups as a critical developmental experience. Furthermore, there are no adaptation studies available for the BDS, and the original study introducing the scale was excluded from our review due to low quality (Field et al. 2009). Additionally, no valid measures were used for psychosocial development. This highlights the need for more precise instruments tailored to romantic breakups, including both psychological and developmental dimensions. Most of the existing tools to evaluate psychosocial development are quite ancient and excessively long (e.g., Erikson 1968; Hawley 1988). The development of such instruments is crucial for enabling more advanced comparative studies, such as meta-analyses, to provide a clearer and more comprehensive understanding of the impact of breakups on psychosocial adjustment.

Research also suggests that the effect of breakup on psychosocial outcomes may be constrained, because it is not adequately addressed through longitudinal studies (Blekesaune 2008; Gibb et al. 2011). This systematic review only engages eleven out of

47 longitudinal studies, all associated with different outcomes or designs, making comprehensive and deep comparisons a challenge. Palacio-González et al. (2017), who analysed breakup distress over time, emphasized the importance of considering temporal dimensions in understanding the complexities of breakup responses. The absence of rigorous, mixed-methods approaches or longitudinal designs restricted a deeper understanding of this phenomenon and the evolution of psychosocial effects over time. Addressing these limitations in future research is crucial to improving the robustness and applicability of findings in the field.

The sample characteristics are an additional consideration when analysing the results, as they may significantly influence the findings. Firstly, a large portion of the participants in the studies were psychology students or college students, which could introduce biases due to their unique experiences. Secondly, there was a higher representation of female participants and, notably, individuals who initiated the breakup, which could influence the results given their different emotional and psychological experiences compared to noninitiators. Initiators may feel more comfortable sharing their feelings and experiences, whereas noninitiators might feel more vulnerable or reluctant to discuss their breakup. This limitation suggests that results from a more generalized sample could be even more concerning. Thirdly, the time since breakup in most studies was relatively short, with an average of approximately 10 months and some studies measuring outcomes just a few weeks after the dissolution. This short time frame may limit the ability to capture the long-term psychological and psychosocial effects of breakups. Fourthly, the studies reviewed were mostly conducted across America, highlighting the importance of careful interpretation of findings. Differences in societal norms, relational dynamics and access to mental health resources could significantly influence how individuals experience and cope with breakups, and these regional differences may not always be adequately addressed. Fifthly, the average age of participants was 21 years old. This youth population could have different coping mechanisms, emotional responses and developmental concerns compared to older emerging adults. Moreover, because studies were selected based on mean sample age between 18 and 29 years to capture emerging adulthood, it is possible that some participants were outside this period range. Together, these limitations may influence the results and the generalizability of the findings. Lastly, the included studies provide limited information regarding participants and relationship identities, making it difficult to assess the generalizability of the findings across diverse populations and relationship formats. Future research could explore whether different relationship formats are associated with different trajectories of psychosocial adjustment following a breakup. Longitudinal studies with more diverse participant samples would also enhance a more comprehensive understanding of the long-term effects of breakups. Comparative and generational studies that analysed psychosocial development after a breakup would also provide data for different populations to better understand the relevance of this experience for young adults and different cultures.

The strengths of this systematic review include: (1) the comprehensive inclusion of all published studies since 2000 from three databases; (2) the focus on psychosocial effects, that it is a complex and multifaceted construct to be analysed; (3) the studies

were selected based on eligible criteria and data were extracted through a systematic process conducted by two independent researchers; (4) one key implication is the critical understanding of the relevance and utility of breakup experiences for psychological health and psychosocial development.

6 | Future Directions

The findings of this review underscore the importance of integrating breakup experiences into psychological and developmental frameworks. Therefore, interventions should address not only the immediate distress of breakups but also deeper self-structuring patterns that shape relational dynamics. It is important to strengthen peer and therapeutic support systems in both academic and clinical settings, ensuring that emerging adults navigating intimacy challenges have access to support and healthier mechanisms. Drawing from attachment and developmental theories (e.g., Ainsworth and Bowlby 1991; Arnett 2000; Erikson 1959; Levinson 1986) and self-perspectives (e.g., Bowen 1978; Kohut 1977), interventions should emphasize identity reconstruction, secure attachment formation and the integration of past relational experiences, shifting self-perceptions and providing tools to navigate future relationships more effectively.

Additionally, future research should focus on longitudinal designs to capture the evolving impact of breakups over time, refining the predictive accuracy of individual and contextual factors in long-term trajectories of psychosocial development. It is also crucial to develop standardized breakup-specific measures to assess both psychological health and developmental change. It is recommended that researchers use consistent measures to enhance comparability and reliability across studies. Examining cross-cultural variations would also provide a better understanding of how breakup experiences differ across societal norms and relationship expectations. Furthermore, future studies should explore the efficacy of targeted intervention, both focused on psychological adjustment and developmental growth.

7 | Conclusions

In summary, this study highlighted the distinct contributions of romantic breakups on psychosocial adjustment. The findings emphasize the dynamics between breakup distress, the broader impact of the event on individuals' self-concept and intimacy and psychosocial well-being following a breakup. Although distressing, romantic breakups also represent a pivotal developmental transition, shaping future relational and self-developmental trajectories. Overall, these findings collectively highlight the significance of individual and contextual factors such as early experiences, coping strategies, emotional mechanisms and psychological resources in determining the degree of challenge posed by the relationship dissolution. Psychological mechanisms played a central role in postdissolution growth and development over time. Future research should continue refining theoretical models, intervention strategies and measurement tools to better support individuals navigating this complex life transition.

Author Contributions

Conceptualization: Joana G. Fernandes and Mariana V. Martins. Methodology: Joana G. Fernandes. Data selection: Joana G. Fernandes and Carina Santos. Data analysis: Joana G. Fernandes. Writing – original draft: Joana G. Fernandes. Writing – review and editing: Joana G. Fernandes, Carina Santos and Mariana V. Martins. Funding acquisition: Joana G. Fernandes, Carina Santos and Mariana V. Martins. Supervision: Mariana V. Martins.

Data Availability Statement

The data that support the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request, including Data S1.

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Supporting Information

Additional supporting information can be found online in the Supporting Information section. **Data S1:** Supporting Information. **Data S2:** Supporting Information. **Data S3:** Supporting Information.